Motivic Homotopy Theory

(Draft)

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Preface

These notes grew out of my participation in Marc Hoyois's Oberseminar on motivic cohomology at the University of Regensburg (SoSe 2026), combined with my own study of the subject. The primary references are the work of Bachmann–Hoyois [BH21] on norms, and the recent paper of Bachmann–Elmanto–Morrow [BEM25].

The goal is to give a self-contained introduction to motivic homotopy theory.

Warning. *This document is a preliminary draft. It likely contains errors, incomplete arguments, and missing references. In particular, some parts of this document were drafted with AI assistance, which may have introduced inaccurate or fabricated citations; readers who notice such discrepancies are encouraged to contact the author. Corrections and suggestions are always welcome.*

Conventions

Throughout these notes, we work in the framework of ∞-categories. The word "category" means ∞-category unless otherwise specified; we write "ordinary category" or "1-category" for the classical notion.

All schemes are assumed to be quasi-compact and quasi-separated unless otherwise stated.

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Chapter 1.

Unstable Motivic Homotopy Theory

The starting point of motivic homotopy theory is a striking analogy between algebraic geometry and topology. In topology, for any paracompact Hausdorff space X, the projection $X \times I \to X$ (with $I = [0,1]$) induces a bijection

$$\pi_0 \mathsf{Vect}_r^{\mathrm{top}}(X) \xrightarrow{\sim} \pi_0 \mathsf{Vect}_r^{\mathrm{top}}(X \times I).$$

Vector bundles, and many other invariants, are insensitive to the cylinder direction. The classical Quillen–Suslin theorem [Qui76; Sus76] provides the algebraic counterpart: every finitely generated projective module over $k[x_1, \ldots, x_n]$ is free, equivalently, the pullback

$$\pi_0 \mathsf{Vect}_r(\mathrm{Spec}(k)) \xrightarrow{\sim} \pi_0 \mathsf{Vect}_r(\mathbb{A}^n_k)$$

is a bijection. Under this analogy, the affine line $\mathbb{A}^1$ plays the role of the interval I: both serve as "cylinder objects" in their respective categories, suggesting a homotopy theory for algebraic geometry in which the projection $\mathbb{A}^1 \times X \to X$ is declared a homotopy equivalence.

Supporting this intuition, many cohomology theories on smooth schemes are $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant. For a smooth scheme X over a field k:

- **Chow groups:** $\mathrm{CH}^*(X) \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathrm{CH}^*(X \times \mathbb{A}^1)$;
- **Grothendieck group:** $\mathrm{K}_0(X) \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathrm{K}_0(X \times \mathbb{A}^1)$;
- **Étale cohomology** (for ℓ invertible in k): $\mathrm{H}^*_{\text{ét}}(X, \mu_\ell) \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathrm{H}^*_{\text{ét}}(X \times \mathbb{A}^1, \mu_\ell)$.

***Remark* 1.0.1** ($\mathbb{A}^1$-invariance fails on non-affine schemes)**.** The functor $\pi_0 \mathsf{Vect}_r \colon \mathsf{Sm}_k^{\mathrm{op}} \to \mathsf{Set}$ is *not* $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant in general. Take the rank-2 bundle E on $\mathbb{P}^1 \times \mathbb{A}^1$ obtained by gluing the trivial bundle on the standard charts $U_0 = \mathrm{Spec}(k[x]) \times \mathbb{A}^1$ and $U_1 = \mathrm{Spec}(k[x^{-1}]) \times \mathbb{A}^1$ via the transition matrix

$$g_{01}(x,t) = \begin{pmatrix} x & t \\ 0 & x^{-1} \end{pmatrix} \in \mathrm{GL}_2\big(k[x, x^{-1}, t]\big).$$

At $t = 0$, the matrix is diagonal, giving $E|_{\mathbb{P}^1 \times \{0\}} \simeq \mathcal{O}(1) \oplus \mathcal{O}(-1)$. At $t = 1$, the matrix defines a non-trivial extension

$$0 \longrightarrow \mathcal{O}(-1) \longrightarrow E|_{\mathbb{P}^1 \times \{1\}} \longrightarrow \mathcal{O}(1) \longrightarrow 0$$

whose class in $\mathrm{Ext}^1(\mathcal{O}(1), \mathcal{O}(-1)) = H^1(\mathbb{P}^1, \mathcal{O}(-2)) \cong k$ is non-zero; by Grothendieck's splitting theorem, this extension is isomorphic as a vector bundle to $\mathcal{O} \oplus \mathcal{O}$. Since $E|_{\mathbb{P}^1 \times \{0\}} \not\simeq E|_{\mathbb{P}^1 \times \{1\}}$ on $\mathbb{P}^1$, the bundle E cannot lie in the image of $\pi_0 \mathsf{Vect}_2(\mathbb{P}^1) \to \pi_0 \mathsf{Vect}_2(\mathbb{P}^1 \times \mathbb{A}^1)$.

Nevertheless—and this is the deep theorem of Morel [Mor12], simplified by Asok–Hoyois–Wendt [AHW17]—if we forcibly $\mathbb{A}^1$-localize Vect_r, the resulting functor still computes the correct values on *smooth affine* schemes. This affine representability theorem is one of the cornerstone applications of motivic homotopy theory.

Overview of the construction. Fix a quasi-compact quasi-separated scheme S, and let Sm_S denote the category of smooth S-schemes of finite presentation. Our goal is to construct the **motivic homotopy category** $\mathsf{H}(S)$: an enlargement of Sm_S in which the projections $\mathbb{A}^1 \times_S X \to X$ become equivalences. The construction proceeds in three universal steps, each with a clear geometric meaning:

(i) **Sifted cocompletion.** Embed Sm_S into $\mathcal{P}_\Sigma(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$, the category of presheaves of anima that convert finite coproducts to finite products.

(ii) **Nisnevich descent.** Force a chosen class of étale-like covers (the *Nisnevich covers*) to become equivalences, yielding $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis}}(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$.

(iii) **$\mathbb{A}^1$-localization.** Force the projections $\mathbb{A}^1 \times X \to X$ to become equivalences, yielding the motivic homotopy category $\mathsf{H}(S)$.

***Remark* 1.0.2** (Why $\mathcal{P}_\Sigma$ rather than PShv?)**.** One could equally well start from the full presheaf category $\mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$. The advantage of $\mathcal{P}_\Sigma(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$ is threefold:

(i) Since Sm_S is extensive, $\mathcal{P}_\Sigma(\mathsf{Sm}_S) \simeq \mathsf{Shv}_\sqcup(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$ [BH21, Lemma 2.4], which is already a topos for the coproduct topology.

(ii) The Yoneda embedding $\mathsf{Sm}_S \hookrightarrow \mathcal{P}_\Sigma(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$ preserves finite coproducts, and every object is a sifted colimit of representables.

(iii) The universal property of $\mathcal{P}_\Sigma$ as the free sifted cocompletion is essential to the construction of norm functors in Appendix A; see [BH21, §3].

Since finite coproduct decompositions are themselves Nisnevich covers, we have natural inclusions

$$\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis}}(\mathsf{Sm}_S) \subset \mathcal{P}_\Sigma(\mathsf{Sm}_S) \subset \mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S),$$

and we write $\mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{Nis}} \colon \mathcal{P}_\Sigma(\mathsf{Sm}_S) \to \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis}}(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$ for the Nisnevich sheafification functor.

1.1. The Nisnevich Topology

The Nisnevich topology, also called the completely decomposed topology, sits strictly between Zariski and étale. In motivic homotopy theory, this choice is forced by two complementary optimality conditions: it is the coarsest topology for which the purity theorem holds, and the finest for which algebraic K-theory is representable (Remark 1.1.1).

1.1.1. Three topologies

For S qcqs, there are three commonly used Grothendieck topologies on Sm_S:

$$\mathrm{Zar} \subset \mathrm{Nis} \subset \text{ét}.$$

- **Zariski:** covers are jointly surjective open immersions.
- **Étale:** covers are jointly surjective étale morphisms.
- **Nisnevich:** covers are jointly surjective étale morphisms with the additional requirement that no residue field extensions occur.

The functor-of-points perspective makes the Nisnevich condition transparent. For a smooth k-scheme X, an étale cover $\{U_i \to X\}$ need not satisfy $\coprod_i U_i(k) \twoheadrightarrow X(k)$: the preimage of a k-rational point might only exist over a finite separable extension L/k. A Nisnevich cover excludes precisely this phenomenon—every k-rational point lifts without field extension.

***Remark* 1.1.1** (Why Nisnevich?). The Nisnevich topology is characterized by two complementary optimality conditions:

- **Coarsest topology for which purity holds.** The purity theorem asserts that for a closed immersion $Z \hookrightarrow X$ in Sm_S with normal bundle ν_Z, there is an $\mathbb{A}^1$-local equivalence $X/(X \setminus Z) \simeq \mathrm{Th}(\nu_Z)$. The Zariski topology is too coarse for this.
- **Finest topology for which K-theory is representable.** Non-connective K-theory $\mathrm{K}\colon \mathsf{Sm}_S^{\mathrm{op}} \to \mathsf{Sp}$ satisfies Nisnevich descent but not étale descent.

1.1.2. Nisnevich covers

Definition 1.1.2 (Nisnevich cover). A family of étale morphisms $(f_i\colon U_i \to X)_{i\in I}$ in Sm_S is a **Nisnevich cover** if for every $x \in X$, there exists $i \in I$ and $u \in U_i$ with $f_i(u) = x$ and $\kappa(u) \xrightarrow{\sim} \kappa(x)$.

***Remark* 1.1.3.** The term "completely decomposed" originates in arithmetic: a prime ideal $\mathfrak{p}$ of $\mathcal{O}_K$ is "completely decomposed" in an étale cover precisely when its residue field does not extend.

Theorem 1.1.4 (Equivalent characterizations). *Let X be qcqs and $(f_i\colon U_i \to X)_{i\in I}$ a family of étale morphisms. The following are equivalent:*

(i) ***(Rational points)*** *For every $x \in X$, there exists i and $u \in U_i$ with $f_i(u) = x$ and $\kappa(u) \xrightarrow{\sim} \kappa(x)$.*

(ii) ***(Finite stratification)*** *There is a chain of finitely presented closed subschemes*

$$\varnothing = Z_0 \subset Z_1 \subset \cdots \subset Z_n = X$$

such that some f_i admits a section over each stratum $Y_j = Z_j \setminus Z_{j-1}$.

(iii) ***(Refinement by Nisnevich squares)*** *There is a stratification as above and a finitely presented étale family $(g_j\colon V_j \to X)_{j=1}^n$ refining (f_i), with each g_j restricting to an isomorphism over Y_j.*

Proof. The implications (iii) $\Rightarrow$ (ii) $\Rightarrow$ (i) are immediate. We prove (i) $\Rightarrow$ (iii).

Replacing each U_i by an affine open cover, we may assume all U_i are quasi-compact and separated, hence all f_i are of finite presentation. Consider the collection of closed subschemes $Y \subseteq X$ for which (iii) fails; we show this collection is empty by Zorn's lemma.

Let $(Y_\alpha)_{\alpha\in A}$ be a descending chain and $Y = \bigcap_\alpha Y_\alpha$. If (iii) holds for Y, then by finite presentation it holds for some Y_α (limits of finitely presented data along cofiltered systems). Hence if (iii) fails, there exists a minimal closed $Y \subseteq X$ for which it fails. Replacing X by Y, we may assume (iii) fails for X but holds for all proper closed subschemes.

Clearly $X \neq \varnothing$. Take a generic point $x \in X$. By (i), for some i there is a morphism $\mathrm{Spec}(\kappa(x)) \to U_i$ lifting $\mathrm{Spec}(\kappa(x)) \to X$. Since $\mathcal{O}_{X,x}^{\mathrm{red}} = \kappa(x)$, the nilpotent lifting property of étale morphisms yields a lift $\mathrm{Spec}(\mathcal{O}_{X,x}) \to U_i$. Passing to a limit, we obtain a quasi-compact open neighborhood $V \subseteq X$ of x and a section $s\colon V \to U_i$.

Take a finitely presented closed $Z \subset X$ with $V = X \setminus Z$. By minimality, (iii) holds for Z: there is a stratification $\varnothing = Z_0 \subset \cdots \subset Z_n = Z$ and a refining family $(h_j\colon W_j \to Z)$ with the required properties. For each j, lift W_j to a finitely presented open $V_j \subseteq U_{i_j}$ with $g_j\colon V_j \to X$ étale and an isomorphism over Y_j. Extending the chain to $\varnothing = Z_0 \subset \cdots \subset Z_n \subset Z_{n+1} = X$ with $V_{n+1} = V$ and $g_{n+1} = f_i \circ s$ realizes (iii) for X, contradicting minimality. □

For a qcqs scheme X, the **small Nisnevich topos** X_{Nis} of X is the topos of Nisnevich sheaves of animae on the category $\mathsf{Et}_X^{\mathrm{fp}}$ of finitely presented étale X-schemes.

Proposition 1.1.5 ([BH21, A.3]). *Let X be a qcqs scheme.*

(i) For every $Y \in \mathsf{Et}_X^{\mathrm{fp}}$ and every point $y \in Y$, the functor

$$F \longmapsto F\big(\operatorname{Spec} \mathcal{O}^h_{Y,y}\big),$$

where $\mathcal{O}^h_{Y,y}$ is the henselization of Y at y, is the inverse image functor of a point of the hypercompletion $X^\wedge_{\mathrm{Nis}}$. These points form a conservative family.

(ii) X_{Nis} is coherent in the sense of [Lur18, Definition A.2.1.6].

1.1.3. Nisnevich squares

The key feature of the Nisnevich topology in practice is that it is generated by a particularly simple class of covers.

Definition 1.1.6 (Nisnevich square). A pullback square in Sm_S

$$\begin{tikzcd} U \times_X V \arrow[r] \arrow[d] \arrow[dr, phantom, "\lrcorner", very near start] & V \arrow[d, "p"] \\ U \arrow[r, hook, "j"'] & X \end{tikzcd}$$

is a **Nisnevich square** if

- j is an open immersion;
- p is étale;
- p induces an isomorphism $p^{-1}(X \setminus U)_{\mathrm{red}} \xrightarrow{\sim} (X \setminus U)_{\mathrm{red}}$.

From the functor-of-points perspective, a Nisnevich square decomposes X's R-points into two classes: those landing in the open U, handled by j; and those in the closed complement $X \setminus U$, covered by p without any residue field extension.

Lemma 1.1.7. *The family $\{j\colon U \hookrightarrow X,\ p\colon V \to X\}$ is a Nisnevich cover of X.*

Proof. For $x \in U$, j has x in its image with trivial residue extension. For $x \in X \setminus U$, the assumption gives $v \in p^{-1}(x)$ with $\kappa(v) \simeq \kappa(x)$. □

The deeper result is that Nisnevich squares *generate* the Nisnevich topology:

Proposition 1.1.8 (Brown–Gersten). *A ($\mathcal{D}$-valued) presheaf $\mathcal{F}$ on Sm_S is a Nisnevich sheaf if and only if $\mathcal{F}(\varnothing)$ is terminal and $\mathcal{F}$ sends every Nisnevich square to a pullback square:*

$$\mathcal{F}(X) \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathcal{F}(V) \times_{\mathcal{F}(U \times_X V)} \mathcal{F}(U).$$

Proof. ($\Rightarrow$) By Lemma 1.1.7, $\{U \hookrightarrow X, V \to X\}$ is a Nisnevich cover, and the sheaf condition directly yields the claimed pullback square. Applying the sheaf condition to the empty cover of $\varnothing$ shows that $\mathcal{F}(\varnothing)$ is terminal.

($\Leftarrow$) Assume $\mathcal{F}$ sends Nisnevich squares to pullbacks. We show that $\mathcal{F}$ satisfies the sheaf condition for any Nisnevich cover of X. By Theorem 1.1.4(iii), there is a refining family $(g_i\colon V_i \to X)_{i=1}^n$ together with a stratification $\varnothing = Z_0 \subset \cdots \subset Z_n = X$ such that each g_i is an isomorphism over Y_i. We proceed by induction on n.

For $n = 0$, we have $X = \varnothing$, and the hypothesis on $\mathcal{F}(\varnothing)$ gives the result. For $n \geq 1$, set $U = X \setminus Z_1$, so that the inclusion $\iota\colon U \hookrightarrow X$ is an open immersion with complement Z_1. Since g_1 is an isomorphism over Z_1, the pair $\{U \hookrightarrow X,\ V_1 \to X\}$ forms a Nisnevich square, giving

$$\mathcal{F}(X) \simeq \mathcal{F}(V_1) \times_{\mathcal{F}(U \times_X V_1)} \mathcal{F}(U).$$

The induced stratification on U has length $n-1$, so by the inductive hypothesis $\mathcal{F}$ satisfies descent for the induced covers of U and of $U \times_X V_1$. Pasting pullbacks finishes the proof. □

***Warning* 1.1.9** (Non-subcanonicality)**.** The Nisnevich topology is *not* subcanonical: representable presheaves $y(X) = \mathrm{Map}_{\mathsf{Sm}_S}(-, X)$ are in general not Nisnevich sheaves. Concretely, Nisnevich descent for h_X would require X-points to glue along Nisnevich covers, but this already fails for henselizations: the henselian local ring $\mathcal{O}^h_{Y,y}$ is the colimit of étale neighborhoods of y, yet $X(\mathcal{O}^h_{Y,y})$ generally does *not* agree with $\operatorname{colim} X(U)$ over those neighborhoods unless X is sufficiently rigid.

Consequently, throughout the construction of $\mathsf{H}(S)$ we must Nisnevich-sheafify representables before working with them. The same warning applies, a fortiori, to the cdh topology of §2.2.2.

1.1.4. Examples

Example 1.1.10 (Zariski covers are Nisnevich)**.** Open immersions induce identity maps on residue fields, so Zariski covers are automatically Nisnevich. The standard cover $\{\mathbb{A}^1, \mathbb{A}^1\} \to \mathbb{P}^1$ corresponds to the Nisnevich square

$$\begin{tikzcd} \mathbb{G}_m \arrow[r] \arrow[d] & \mathbb{A}^1 \arrow[d] \\ \mathbb{A}^1 \arrow[r] & \mathbb{P}^1. \end{tikzcd}$$

Example 1.1.11 (The m-th power map)**.** Let k be a field with $\mathrm{char}(k) \nmid m$ and $a \in k^\times$. Consider

$$\begin{aligned} f\colon (\mathbb{A}^1 \setminus \{a\}) \sqcup (\mathbb{A}^1 \setminus \{0\}) &\longrightarrow \mathbb{A}^1, \\ \text{first component:} \quad x &\longmapsto x, \\ \text{second component:} \quad y &\longmapsto y^m. \end{aligned}$$

The first component is an open immersion; the second is étale. This f is a Nisnevich cover if and only if a has an m-th root in k.

Example 1.1.12 (Algebraic K-theory is a Nisnevich sheaf)**.** By Brown–Gersten it suffices to check Nisnevich excision (the empty case is trivial). For a Nisnevich square

$$\begin{tikzcd} W \arrow[r] \arrow[d] & V \arrow[d] \\ U \arrow[r, "j"'] & Y, \end{tikzcd}$$

perfect complexes satisfy flat descent, so we obtain a pullback square of stable categories

$$\begin{tikzcd} \mathsf{Perf}(W) & \mathsf{Perf}(V) \arrow[l] \\ \mathsf{Perf}(U) \arrow[u] & \mathsf{Perf}(Y). \arrow[l] \arrow[u] \end{tikzcd}$$

Setting $Z = Y \setminus U = V \setminus W$ and taking horizontal fibers gives a diagram of Karoubi sequences (using full faithfulness of $j_* \colon \mathsf{D}(U) \to \mathsf{D}(Y)$). Since K-theory sends Karoubi sequences to fiber sequences of spectra, the K-theory square is also a pullback.

1.1.5. *Milnor excision*

Restricting to affine schemes, Nisnevich squares take a particularly clean ring-theoretic form.

Definition 1.1.13 (Milnor square). A **Milnor square** for a commutative ring R is a pullback

$$\begin{tikzcd} R \arrow[r] \arrow[d] \arrow[dr, phantom, "\lrcorner", very near start] & R/I \arrow[d] \\ R_f \arrow[r] & R_f/IR_f \end{tikzcd}$$

where $f \in R$, $I \subset R$ is an ideal, and $R/I \xrightarrow{\sim} R_f/IR_f$ (equivalently, f is a unit in R/I).

A Milnor square is precisely a Nisnevich square for affine schemes: $U = \mathrm{Spec}(R_f) \hookrightarrow \mathrm{Spec}(R) = X$ is the principal open defined by f, and $V = \mathrm{Spec}(R/I) \to X$ is a closed immersion. The condition $R/I \simeq R_f/IR_f$ is exactly $p^{-1}(X \setminus U) \simeq X \setminus U$.

Proposition 1.1.14 (Milnor excision). *For every Nisnevich sheaf $\mathcal{F}$ and every Milnor square,*

$$\mathcal{F}(\mathrm{Spec}(R)) \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathcal{F}(\mathrm{Spec}(R_f)) \times_{\mathcal{F}(\mathrm{Spec}(R_f/IR_f))} \mathcal{F}(\mathrm{Spec}(R/I)).$$

1.2. $\mathbb{A}^1$-Localization

Write $\mathsf{PShv}_{\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S) \subset \mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$ for the full subcategory of **$\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant** presheaves: those $\mathcal{F}$ with $\mathcal{F}(U) \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathcal{F}(U \times_S \mathbb{A}^1)$ for all $U \in \mathsf{Sm}_S$. The inclusion admits a left adjoint

$$\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1} \colon \mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S) \longrightarrow \mathsf{PShv}_{\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S),$$

called the **$\mathbb{A}^1$-localization functor**.

Definition 1.2.1 ($\mathbb{A}^1$-local equivalence and $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopy). Let $f \colon \mathcal{F} \to \mathcal{G}$ be a morphism in $\mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$.

- f is an **$\mathbb{A}^1$-local equivalence** if $\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}(f)$ is an isomorphism.
- Two maps $f, g \colon \mathcal{F} \to \mathcal{G}$ are **$\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopic** if there exists $H \colon \mathcal{F} \times \mathbb{A}^1 \to \mathcal{G}$ with $H \circ i_0 \simeq f$ and $H \circ i_1 \simeq g$, where $i_s \colon * \to \mathbb{A}^1$ is the inclusion of $s \in \{0, 1\}$.
- f is an **$\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopy equivalence** if there exists g with fg and gf each $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopic to the appropriate identity.

Proposition 1.2.2. *Every $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopy equivalence is an $\mathbb{A}^1$-local equivalence. In particular, the projection $p \colon \mathcal{F} \times \mathbb{A}^1 \to \mathcal{F}$ is an $\mathbb{A}^1$-local equivalence for every $\mathcal{F}$.*

Proof. We first show $p \colon X \times \mathbb{A}^1 \to X$ is an $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopy equivalence for every $X \in \mathsf{Sm}_S$ (and hence, by universal colimits in PShv, for every presheaf). The zero section $s \colon X \to X \times \mathbb{A}^1$ satisfies $p \circ s = \mathrm{id}_X$. The reverse composite $s \circ p$ is $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopic to $\mathrm{id}_{X \times \mathbb{A}^1}$ via

$$(X \times \mathbb{A}^1) \times \mathbb{A}^1 \xrightarrow{\mathrm{id}_X \times \mu} X \times \mathbb{A}^1,$$

where $\mu\colon \mathbb{A}^1 \times \mathbb{A}^1 \to \mathbb{A}^1$ is the ring multiplication: at $t = 1$ this gives $\mathrm{id}_{X\times\mathbb{A}^1}$, at $t = 0$ it gives $s \circ p$.

Now suppose $a, b\colon \mathcal{F} \to \mathcal{G}$ are $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopic via H. Since $p \circ i_0 = p \circ i_1 = \mathrm{id}$ and $\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}(p)$ is an isomorphism, applying $\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}$ gives $\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}(i_0) = \mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}(i_1)$. Hence

$$\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}(a) = \mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}(H) \circ \mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}(i_0) = \mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}(H) \circ \mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}(i_1) = \mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}(b).$$

The result follows from the definition of homotopy equivalence. □

1.2.1. *Interval objects*

We have encountered three a priori distinct notions: $\mathbb{A}^1$-localization, localization at $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopy equivalences, and the $\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}$-construction via $\Delta^\bullet$. Do they coincide? Following Hoyois [Hoy], the answer is yes, and this is a formal consequence of $\mathbb{A}^1$ being an **interval object**.

Definition 1.2.3 (Bipointed object)**.** Let $\mathcal{C}$ be a category with finite products. A **bipointed object** is an object $I \in \mathcal{C}$ with two global sections $0, 1\colon * \rightrightarrows I$.

Definition 1.2.4 (Three homotopy categories)**.** Let $\mathcal{C}$ have finite products and I be a bipointed object.

(i) **I-localization** (nullification): formally invert all projections $X \times I \to X$:

$$\mathcal{C}/I \;:=\; \mathcal{C}\left[\{X \times I \to X\}^{-1}\right].$$

(ii) **Localization at I-homotopy equivalences**:

$$\mathcal{C}\left[\mathrm{hoeq}_I^{-1}\right].$$

(iii) **I-homotopy category**, via simplicial enrichment:

$$\mathrm{Ho}(\mathcal{C}, I), \qquad \mathrm{Map}_{\mathrm{Ho}(\mathcal{C},I)}(X, Y) = \mathrm{colim}_{\Delta^{\mathrm{op}}} \mathrm{Map}_{\mathcal{C}}(X \times I^n, Y).$$

In general, there are canonical functors

$$\mathcal{C}\left[\mathrm{hoeq}_I^{-1}\right] \longrightarrow \mathrm{Ho}(\mathcal{C}, I) \longrightarrow \mathcal{C}/I,$$

neither of which is generally an equivalence.

Definition 1.2.5 (Interval object)**.** A bipointed object $I \in \mathcal{C}$ is an **interval object** if

(i) $X \times I$ exists for all $X \in \mathcal{C}$;

(ii) I is I-contractible: $I \to *$ is an I-homotopy equivalence.

Example 1.2.6.

- The unit interval $[0, 1] \in \mathsf{Top}$ with multiplication $\mu(x, y) = xy$.
- The affine line $\mathbb{A}^1 \in \mathsf{Sm}_S$ with ring multiplication.
- The real line $\mathbb{R}$ and complex plane $\mathbb{C}$ in Top, both with multiplication.

Theorem 1.2.7 (Morel–Voevodsky [MV99])**.** *For any category $\mathcal{C}$ and interval object $I \in \mathcal{C}$,*

$$\mathcal{C}\left[\mathrm{hoeq}_I^{-1}\right] \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathrm{Ho}(\mathcal{C}, I) \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathcal{C}/I.$$

Proof sketch. **Left equivalence.** I-contractibility provides a zigzag of I-homotopies connecting id_I to the constant map $0\colon I \to * \to I$. Taking products with X shows that $(\mathrm{id}_X, 0)\colon X \to X \times I$ is an I-homotopy inverse to pr_1, so every projection $X \times I \to X$ is an I-homotopy equivalence.

Right equivalence. The I-homotopy from id_I to 0 induces a simplicial homotopy between the corresponding endomorphisms of $\mathrm{Map}(I \times I^\bullet, Y)$. After $\mathrm{colim}_{\mathbf{\Delta}^{\mathrm{op}}}$ this becomes an isomorphism, identifying mapping anima in $\mathrm{Ho}(\mathcal{C}, I)$ with those in $\mathcal{C}/I$. □

Corollary 1.2.8. *The affine line $\mathbb{A}^1$ with sections $0, 1$ and ring multiplication is an interval object in Sm_S and in $\mathcal{P}_\Sigma(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$. Hence the three a priori distinct notions in §1.2 coincide on $\mathcal{P}_\Sigma(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$:*

(i) $\mathbb{A}^1$-localization (inverting $\mathcal{F} \times \mathbb{A}^1 \to \mathcal{F}$);

(ii) localization at $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopy equivalences;

(iii) the singular complex $\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}$.

***Remark* 1.2.9.** The multiplication $\mu(x, y) = xy$ on $\mathbb{A}^1$ provides the $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopy from $\mathrm{id}_{\mathbb{A}^1}$ (at $y = 1$) to the constant map 0 (at $y = 0$). This is why 1, not 0, plays the role of the basepoint: the unit of the multiplication is the structure that makes $\mathbb{A}^1$ an interval object.

1.2.2. *Explicit formula for* $\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}$

Corollary 1.2.8 identifies $\mathbb{A}^1$-localization abstractly with the $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopy category $\mathrm{Ho}(\mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S), \mathbb{A}^1)$, whose mapping anima are given by $\mathrm{colim}_{\mathbf{\Delta}^{\mathrm{op}}} \mathrm{Map}(- \times \mathbb{A}^\bullet, -)$. We now convert this into an explicit "singular complex" formula, modelled on its topological namesake.

The $\mathbb{A}^1$-localization functor admits an explicit formula via an algebraic singular complex.

Definition 1.2.10 (Algebraic simplex)**.** The standard n-simplex over S is

$$\Delta^n_S \;:=\; \mathrm{Spec}\big(\mathcal{O}_S[T_0, \dots, T_n]/(T_0 + \cdots + T_n - 1)\big) \;\subset\; \mathbb{A}^{n+1}_S.$$

Face and degeneracy maps are defined as in topology, yielding a cosimplicial scheme $\Delta^\bullet_S\colon \mathbf{\Delta} \to \mathsf{Sch}_S$. Note $\Delta^n_S \simeq \mathbb{A}^n_S$ as S-schemes (but not as cosimplicial objects).

Theorem 1.2.11 (Explicit formula for $\mathbb{A}^1$-localization)**.** *For $\mathcal{F} \in \mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$ and $X \in \mathsf{Sm}_S$,*

$$(\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}\mathcal{F})(X) \;\simeq\; \mathrm{colim}_{[n]\in\mathbf{\Delta}^{\mathrm{op}}} \mathcal{F}(X \times \Delta^n_S).$$

Proof. Write $\mathcal{F}'(X) := \mathrm{colim}_{[n]\in\mathbf{\Delta}^{\mathrm{op}}} \mathcal{F}(X \times \Delta^n_S)$.

$\mathbb{A}^1$-invariance. The projection $p\colon X \times \mathbb{A}^1 \to X$ and zero section s induce maps on the cosimplicial objects $X \times \Delta^\bullet_S$ and $X \times \mathbb{A}^1 \times \Delta^\bullet_S$. We have $s^* \circ p^* = \mathrm{id}$, and the multiplication $\mu\colon \mathbb{A}^1 \times \mathbb{A}^1 \to \mathbb{A}^1$ defines an $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopy $p^*s^* \simeq \mathrm{id}$. Since $\Delta^1_S \simeq \mathbb{A}^1_S$, this $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopy translates into a simplicial homotopy on $\mathcal{F}(X \times \Delta^\bullet_S)$ between p^*s^* and id, which becomes an equivalence after $\mathrm{colim}_{\mathbf{\Delta}^{\mathrm{op}}}$. Hence $p^*\colon \mathcal{F}'(X) \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathcal{F}'(X \times \mathbb{A}^1)$.

Universal property. Let $\mathcal{G}$ be $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant. Since $\Delta^n_S \simeq \mathbb{A}^n_S$, $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariance forces $\mathcal{G}(X \times \Delta^\bullet_S)$ to have all simplicial structure maps acting as equivalences; hence $\mathrm{colim}_{\mathbf{\Delta}^{\mathrm{op}}} \mathcal{G}(X \times \Delta^\bullet_S) \simeq \mathcal{G}(X)$. Therefore

$$\mathrm{Map}(\mathcal{F}', \mathcal{G}) \simeq \lim_{\mathbf{\Delta}} \mathrm{Map}(\mathcal{F}(- \times \Delta^n_S), \mathcal{G}) \simeq \mathrm{Map}\big(\mathcal{F}, \lim_{\mathbf{\Delta}} \mathcal{G}(- \times \Delta^n_S)\big) \simeq \mathrm{Map}(\mathcal{F}, \mathcal{G}). \qquad \square$$

***Remark* 1.2.12** (Geometric meaning)**.** Theorem 1.2.11 is the algebro-geometric analogue of the topological singular complex $\mathrm{Sing}_\bullet$. The simplicial anima $\mathcal{F}(X \times \Delta^\bullet_S)$ encodes algebraic homotopy information: 0-simplices are sections, 1-simplices parametrize $\mathbb{A}^1$-paths, 2-simplices parametrize higher homotopies. Taking the colimit over $\mathbf{\Delta}^{\mathrm{op}}$ quotients out all $\mathbb{A}^1$-deformations.

Caveat: $\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}$ does not generally preserve Nisnevich sheaves, so the motivic localization $\mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{mot}}$ is *not* simply $\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1} \circ \mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{Nis}}$; see Remark 1.3.3.

1.3. Motivic Spaces

We now assemble the construction. Let S be qcqs. Since Sm_S is extensive, $\mathcal{P}_\Sigma(\mathsf{Sm}_S) \simeq \mathsf{Shv}_{\sqcup}(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$, and finite coproduct decompositions are Nisnevich covers, so $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis}}(\mathsf{Sm}_S) \subset \mathcal{P}_\Sigma(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$.

Definition 1.3.1 (Motivic spaces)**.** The category of **motivic spaces** over S is

$$\mathsf{H}(S) \;:=\; \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis}}(\mathsf{Sm}_S) \cap \mathsf{PShv}_{\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S) \;\subset\; \mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S),$$

consisting of presheaves of anima satisfying both Nisnevich descent and $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariance. The corresponding localization functor is

$$\mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{mot}} \colon \mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S) \longrightarrow \mathsf{H}(S).$$

A morphism in $\mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$ is a **motivic equivalence** if $\mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{mot}}$ sends it to an equivalence.

Fact 1.3.2. *(i) $\mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{Nis}}$ is left exact. Both $\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}$ and $\mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{mot}}$ preserve finite products [Hoy14, Proposition C.6].*

(ii) Motivic equivalences form the smallest strongly saturated class in $\mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$ containing both Nisnevich-local and $\mathbb{A}^1$-local equivalences.

***Remark* 1.3.3** (Non-commutativity of localizations)**.** In general, neither $\mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{mot}} = \mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1} \circ \mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{Nis}}$ nor $\mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{mot}} = \mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{Nis}} \circ \mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}$ holds: $\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}$ can destroy Nisnevich descent, while $\mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{Nis}}$ can destroy $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariance. Nevertheless, $\mathsf{H}(S)$ is defined as an intersection, and is therefore independent of the order of localization. Concretely, the motivic localization is computed by ping-ponging:

$$\mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{mot}} \;\simeq\; (\mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{Nis}} \circ \mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1})^{\circ \mathbb{N}},$$

i.e., by alternating the two localizations transfinitely until the process stabilizes (c.f. [AE16, Theorem 4.27]).

In the spectra-valued setting, however, $\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}$ preserves Nisnevich descent, since Sp is stable (then cartesian in Proposition 1.1.8 is also cocartesian); that is, one obtains a functor

$$\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1} \circ \mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{Nis}} \colon \mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp}) \to \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp}).$$

1.3.1. Motivic spaces and K-theory

Recall from Remark 1.0.1 that BGL_r, after motivic localization, classifies rank-r vector bundles on smooth affine schemes. Stabilizing with respect to rank via the direct-sum maps $E \mapsto E \oplus \mathcal{O}$ yields

$$\mathrm{BGL}_\infty \;:=\; \mathrm{colim}_n \, \mathrm{BGL}_n \;\in\; \mathsf{H}(S),$$

which classifies stable vector bundles up to addition of trivial summands; the $\mathbb{Z}$ factor in what follows records the virtual rank. This is the motivic analogue of the classical topological identification $\mathbb{Z} \times \mathrm{BU} \simeq \mathrm{ku}$ for the connective complex K-theory spectrum, and the special case $r = 1$ gives $\mathrm{BGL}_1 = \mathrm{B}\mathbb{G}_m$, classifying line bundles.

Concretely, connective algebraic K-theory $\mathrm{k} \colon \mathsf{Sm}_S^{\mathrm{op}} \to \mathsf{An}$ satisfies Nisnevich descent (Example 1.1.12) and is $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant when the base is regular, hence defines an object of $\mathsf{H}(S)$.

Theorem 1.3.4 (Representability of K-theory). *For S regular Noetherian of finite Krull dimension,*

$$\mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{mot}}(\mathbb{Z} \times \mathrm{BGL}_\infty) \simeq \mathrm{k}.$$

In particular, for affine $U \in \mathsf{Sm}_S$, $[U, \mathbb{Z} \times \mathrm{BGL}_\infty]_{\mathsf{H}(S)} \simeq \mathrm{K}_0(U)$.

***Remark* 1.3.5** (Affine representability). Although Vect_r is not $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant on all smooth schemes (Remark 1.0.1), motivic localization still yields the correct values on smooth affine schemes: Asok–Hoyois–Wendt [AHW17] proved that if X is a presheaf on Sm_S such that $\pi_0(X)$ is $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant on affine schemes and X satisfies affine Nisnevich excision, then $\pi_0(X)(U) \xrightarrow{\sim} [U, X]_{\mathsf{H}(S)}$ for all smooth affine U. Taking $X = \mathrm{BGL}_r$ gives $\pi_0\mathsf{Vect}_r(U) \simeq [U, \mathrm{BGL}_r]_{\mathsf{H}(S)}$ for affine U.

The connective K-theory anima $\mathrm{k}(X)$ refines to a spectrum-valued functor $\mathrm{K}\colon \mathsf{Sm}_S^{\mathrm{op}} \to \mathsf{Sp}$, recovering k as the connective cover $\tau_{\geq 0}\mathrm{K}$.

Definition 1.3.6 (Higher K-groups). For $X \in \mathsf{Sm}_S$ and $n \in \mathbb{Z}$, the n-th algebraic K-group of X is

$$\mathrm{K}_n(X) \coloneqq \pi_n \mathrm{K}(X).$$

In particular, $\mathrm{K}_0(X)$ is the Grothendieck group of the symmetric monoidal category of perfect complexes on X, and $\mathrm{K}_1(X)$ contains $\mathcal{O}_X(X)^\times$ via the determinant map.

Example 1.3.7 (K-theory of a field). For k a field, $\mathrm{K}_0(k) = \mathbb{Z}$ and $\mathrm{K}_1(k) = k^\times$. Matsumoto's theorem identifies $\mathrm{K}_2(k)$ with the Milnor K-group $\mathrm{K}_2^{\mathrm{M}}(k)$, namely the quotient of $k^\times \otimes_{\mathbb{Z}} k^\times$ by the Steinberg relation $\{a, 1-a\} = 0$ for $a \neq 0, 1$. Closed-form descriptions of $\mathrm{K}_n(k)$ for $n \geq 3$ are generally unavailable.

***Remark* 1.3.8** (The role of regularity). Nisnevich descent of K-theory holds without regularity (Example 1.1.12); $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariance does not. For regular Noetherian X, Quillen proved $\mathrm{K}_n(X) \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathrm{K}_n(X \times \mathbb{A}^1)$ for all $n \geq 0$. For singular schemes this fails: with $R = k[\varepsilon]/(\varepsilon^2)$,

$$\mathrm{K}_1(R[t]) \neq \mathrm{K}_1(R),$$

since $(1 + \varepsilon t) \in R[t]^\times$ contributes a class in $\mathrm{K}_1(R[t])$ not coming from $\mathrm{K}_1(R)$.

To restore $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariance on non-regular schemes, Weibel introduced **homotopy K-theory**

$$\mathrm{KH}(X) \coloneqq \operatorname{colim}_{[n] \in \mathbf{\Delta}^{\mathrm{op}}} \mathrm{K}\big(X \times \Delta^n\big),$$

which is precisely $\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}$ applied to K.

Proposition 1.3.9 (Vanishing of negative K-theory on regular schemes). *For X regular Noetherian, $\mathrm{K}_n(X) = 0$ for all $n < 0$. In particular, $\mathrm{k}(X) \simeq \mathrm{K}(X)$ on regular schemes.*

Proof. $\mathsf{Perf}(X) \simeq \mathsf{D}^b(\mathsf{Coh}(X))$ by regularity, and the latter carries a bounded t-structure with Noetherian heart; the claim follows from Antieau–Gepner–Heller [AGH19, Theorem 1.2]. □

***Remark* 1.3.10** (Bass splitting as a precursor to Bott periodicity). Classically, Bass's fundamental theorem yields a natural splitting

$$\mathrm{K}_n(X \times \mathbb{G}_m) \simeq \mathrm{K}_n(X) \oplus \mathrm{K}_{n-1}(X)$$

for regular X, which is the unstable shadow of a much stronger periodicity: after passing to the stable motivic category and enforcing $\mathbb{P}^1$-periodicity, k is delooped to a motivic ring spectrum $\mathrm{KGL}_S \in \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{SH}(S))$ satisfying Bott periodicity

$$\mathbb{T}_S \otimes \mathrm{KGL}_S \;\simeq\; \mathrm{KGL}_S;$$

see Definition 2.3.9 for the construction. The $\mathbb{G}_m$-direction of Bass's fundamental theorem becomes the $(1,1)$-summand of Bott periodicity; the remaining simplicial S^1-direction requires the projective bundle formula, which has no unstable counterpart.

1.4. Pointed Motivic Spaces

1.4.1. Basic constructions

Definition 1.4.1 (Pointed motivic spaces)**.** The category $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$ of **pointed motivic spaces** is the category of pointed objects in $\mathsf{H}(S)$.

The functor $(-)_+ \colon \mathsf{H}(S) \to \mathsf{H}_*(S)$ adds a disjoint basepoint, $X_+ = X \sqcup *$, and is left adjoint to the forgetful functor.

The **smash product** on $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$ is the pushout

$$X \wedge Y \;:=\; \mathrm{cofib}(X \vee Y \to X \times Y),$$

making $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$ symmetric monoidal with unit S_+.

We adopt the basepoint conventions:

- $\mathbb{A}^1$ is pointed at 1;
- $\mathbb{G}_m$ is pointed at 1;
- $\mathbb{P}^1$ is pointed at $\infty = [1:0]$.

Definition 1.4.2 (Suspension and loops)**.** For $X \in \mathsf{H}_*(S)$,

- the **suspension** $\Sigma X := S^1 \wedge X$, where $S^1 = [1]/\partial[1]$ is the simplicial circle (as a constant sheaf);
- the **loop space** $\Omega X := \mathrm{fib}(* \to X)$.

These form an adjunction $\Sigma \dashv \Omega$.

1.4.2. Bigraded spheres

In $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$ there are two essentially different "circles".

Definition 1.4.3 (Motivic spheres)**.**

- The **simplicial circle** is $S^{1,0} := S^1$ (constant sheaf).
- The **Tate circle** is $S^{1,1} := \mathbb{G}_m$ (pointed at 1).
- The **motivic (p,q)-sphere**, for $p \geq q \geq 0$, is

$$S^{p,q} \;:=\; (S^{1,0})^{\wedge(p-q)} \wedge (S^{1,1})^{\wedge q}.$$

The key computation:

Proposition 1.4.4 ($\mathbb{P}^1$ as a motivic sphere)**.** *In* $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$, $\mathbb{P}^1 \simeq S^{2,1} = S^1 \wedge \mathbb{G}_m$.

Proof. Consider the standard Nisnevich square for $\mathbb{P}^1$:

$$\begin{tikzcd} \mathbb{G}_m \arrow[r] \arrow[d] & \mathbb{A}^1 \arrow[d] \\ \mathbb{A}^1 \arrow[r] & \mathbb{P}^1. \end{tikzcd}$$

By Brown–Gersten in the pointed setting, this is a pushout square in $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$. Since $\mathbb{A}^1 \simeq *$ in $\mathsf{H}(S)$, both copies of $\mathbb{A}^1$ collapse to the basepoint, and the pushout becomes

$$\mathbb{P}^1 \;\simeq\; * \sqcup_{\mathbb{G}_m} * \;\simeq\; \Sigma\mathbb{G}_m \;=\; S^1 \wedge \mathbb{G}_m \;=\; S^{2,1}. \qquad \square$$

***Remark* 1.4.5.** This makes precise the observation that $\mathbb{G}_m$ realizes a kind of "algebraic circle": under Betti realization $\mathbb{G}_m(\mathbb{C}) = \mathbb{C}^\times$ is homotopy equivalent to the topological S^1. The motivic sphere $\mathbb{G}_m$ plays the role of $S^{1,1}$, while the simplicial circle S^1 is $S^{1,0}$. Their smash product $\mathbb{P}^1 \simeq S^{2,1}$ is the natural "algebraic 2-sphere".

This bigraded structure is what makes motivic homotopy theory richer than classical homotopy theory: the weight direction q encodes Tate twists specific to algebraic geometry.

Proposition 1.4.6 (Punctured affine spaces)**.** *For $n \geq 1$, $\mathbb{A}^n \setminus \{0\} \simeq S^{2n-1,n}$ in $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$ (with any choice of basepoint, e.g. $(1, 0, \ldots, 0)$).*

Proof. By induction on n. The case $n = 1$ is $\mathbb{A}^1 \setminus \{0\} = \mathbb{G}_m \simeq S^{1,1}$. For $n \geq 2$, the Nisnevich square

$$\begin{tikzcd} (\mathbb{A}^{n-1} \setminus \{0\}) \times \mathbb{G}_m \arrow[r] \arrow[d] & \mathbb{A}^{n-1} \times \mathbb{G}_m \arrow[d] \\ (\mathbb{A}^{n-1} \setminus \{0\}) \times \mathbb{A}^1 \arrow[r] & \mathbb{A}^n \setminus \{0\} \end{tikzcd}$$

is a pushout in $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$. Since $\mathbb{A}^1 \simeq *$, the right two terms collapse, yielding

$$\mathbb{A}^n \setminus \{0\} \;\simeq\; \Sigma\big((\mathbb{A}^{n-1} \setminus \{0\}) \wedge \mathbb{G}_m\big) \;=\; S^{1,0} \wedge S^{2n-3,n-1} \wedge S^{1,1} \;=\; S^{2n-1,n}. \qquad \square$$

Corollary 1.4.7 (Thom spaces)**.** *In $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$,*

$$\mathbb{A}^n/(\mathbb{A}^n \setminus \{0\}) \;\simeq\; S^{2n,n} \quad \textit{and} \quad \mathbb{P}^n/\mathbb{P}^{n-1} \;\simeq\; S^{2n,n}.$$

Proof. The cofiber sequence $\mathbb{A}^n \setminus \{0\} \to \mathbb{A}^n \to \mathbb{A}^n/(\mathbb{A}^n \setminus \{0\})$ together with $\mathbb{A}^n \simeq *$ gives

$$\mathbb{A}^n/(\mathbb{A}^n \setminus \{0\}) \;\simeq\; \Sigma(\mathbb{A}^n \setminus \{0\}) \;\simeq\; \Sigma S^{2n-1,n} \;=\; S^{2n,n}.$$

For the second, use the standard open cover of $\mathbb{P}^n$ and induction. $\square$

Chapter 2.

Stable Motivic Homotopy Theory

The category $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$ constructed in the previous chapter — pointed objects in $\mathsf{H}(S) = \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis}}(\mathsf{Sm}_S) \cap \mathsf{PShv}_{\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$ — is already rich enough to host a great deal of algebraic geometry. What it lacks is the formal machinery of a stable homotopy theory: fibre and cofibre sequences that coincide, the suspension–loop equivalence $\Sigma \simeq \Omega^{-1}$, and the six-functor formalism that underlies modern thinking about cohomology. All of these become available after one further universal step: formally inverting the Tate object $\mathbb{T}_S \simeq S^1 \wedge \mathbb{G}_m$ under the smash product. The result is $\mathsf{SH}(S)$, the **motivic stable homotopy category**, the central object of this chapter.

The parallel with sheaf theory on a topological space offers a useful compass:

Sheaves on a space X		**Motivic world over S**
$\mathsf{Shv}(X, \mathsf{An})$	$\longleftrightarrow$	$\mathsf{H}(S)$
$\mathsf{Shv}(X, \mathsf{An}_*)$	$\longleftrightarrow$	$\mathsf{H}_*(S)$
$\mathsf{Shv}(X, \mathsf{Sp})$	$\longleftrightarrow$	$\mathsf{SH}(S)$

The correspondence is an abstract guide rather than a literal equivalence: on the motivic side one can also form $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$ by starting from spectrum-valued presheaves on Sm_S and imposing the same two descent conditions, and $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ differs from this naive stabilisation precisely because we have inverted the Tate object rather than the simplicial circle alone. Working out the precise relationship between $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ and $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$ is one of the main goals of this chapter.

Why single out this particular universal construction? Grothendieck envisioned, long before stable categories were available, that every cohomology theory on schemes should factor through a single universal "category of motives". In the modern dictionary "studying cohomology" is increasingly understood as "studying six-functor formalisms", and Grothendieck's programme becomes the search for a universal such formalism.

Drew–Gallauer [DG22] supplied a precise form of this search: there is a universal presentable six-functor formalism on finite-type schemes which is cohomologically smooth, satisfies excision, and kills the $\mathbb{A}^1$-homology. This universal object is the motivic formalism SH of Morel–Voevodsky. The span-category framework underlying this statement is set up in §2.2.1, and the theorem is stated precisely in §2.2.5.

Their proof is constructive and recovers the construction we shall give: the passage to $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_-, \mathsf{Sp})$ is forced by excision, and $\otimes$-inverting $\mathbb{T}_S$ is forced by the triviality of $\mathbb{A}^1$-homology.

It bears emphasising that SH is not the final word: the axioms above — especially $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariance — exclude important arithmetic-geometric cohomology theories. Prismatic cohomology does not factor through SH, and more generally p-adic cohomology theories in characteristic p require fundamentally different frameworks. One should therefore think of $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ as the universal coefficient system for $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant cohomology, not as the definitive answer to Grothendieck's question.

The chapter proceeds in four parts.

- §2.1 constructs $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ as the formal inversion of $\mathbb{T}_S$ in $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$, developing the symmetric-spectrum and telescope models on which the construction rests, and specialising the general machinery to the motivic setting.
- §2.2 equips SH with its six-functor formalism via the span-category framework of Mann and Scholze (in the 2-categorical form due to Cnossen–Lenz–Linskens), deduces cdh descent as a consequence, and establishes the Drew–Gallauer universal property advertised above.
- §2.3 carries out the comparison between $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ and its naive stabilisation $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$ via graded-algebra data and Bott-periodic modules, following Bachmann–Elmanto–Morrow. The resulting dictionary translates classical $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant cohomology theories into motivic ring spectra; we apply it to construct the motivic K-theory spectrum KGL, and we close the section with a study of the homotopy t-structure on $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ and its relationship to the Postnikov t-structure on $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$.
- §2.4 develops Voevodsky's slice filtration together with the categories of effective and very effective motivic spectra, and introduces the theory of orientations and formal group laws.

Two further topics—low-weight motivic cohomology and the motivic Thom spectrum MGL—are taken up in separate sections that complete the chapter.

2.1. Formal inversion

This section gives a careful construction of the stable motivic category $\mathsf{SH}(S)$, together with the technology—symmetric sequences, free algebras, Bousfield localization—needed both for this construction and for the construction of specific motivic spectra in subsequent sections.

Before entering the construction, let us briefly recall the setting established in Chapter 1. For a quasi-compact quasi-separated scheme S, we built $\mathsf{H}(S)$ as the full subcategory

$$\mathsf{H}(S) \;=\; \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis}}(\mathsf{Sm}_S) \cap \mathsf{PShv}_{\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S) \;\subset\; \mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$$

of presheaves of anima satisfying both Nisnevich descent and $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariance. The pointed variant $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$ was obtained by passing to pointed objects, and we defined the Tate object

$$\mathbb{T}_S \;\coloneqq\; \mathrm{cofib}\big(\infty\colon S \hookrightarrow \mathbb{P}^1_S\big) \;\in\; \mathsf{H}_*(S),$$

which by Proposition 1.4.4 is equivalent to $S^1 \wedge \mathbb{G}_m = S^{2,1}$.

The goal of this section is to invert $\mathbb{T}_S$ under the smash product, producing a presentably symmetric monoidal category $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ that extends the construction chain

$$\mathsf{Sm}_S \xrightarrow{よ} \mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S) \xrightarrow{\mathrm{L_{mot}}} \mathsf{H}(S) \xrightarrow{(-)_+} \mathsf{H}_*(S) \xrightarrow{\sigma^\infty_{\mathbb{T}_S}} \mathsf{SH}(S),$$

from Chapter 1 by one further universal step.

2.1.1. *The universal ⊗-inversion problem*

Let $\mathcal{C} \in \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{Pr}^L)$ be a presentably symmetric monoidal category and let $T \in \mathcal{C}$. We seek the initial presentably symmetric monoidal $\mathcal{C}$-algebra in which the image of T becomes ⊗-invertible: that is, the initial object of $\mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{Pr}^L)_{\mathcal{C}/}$ whose structure functor sends T to an invertible object.

Definition 2.1.1. Let $\mathcal{C} \in \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{Pr}^L)$ and $\mathcal{D} \in \mathsf{Mod}_{\mathcal{C}}(\mathsf{Pr}^L)$. Given a Bousfield localization $L\colon \mathcal{D} \to \mathcal{D}'$, we say L is **symmetric monoidal** if the composition $\mathcal{D} \xrightarrow{L} \mathcal{D}' \hookrightarrow \mathcal{D}$ is of the form $A \otimes -$ for some $A \in \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathcal{C})$.

***Remark* 2.1.2.** Symmetric monoidal localizations are also called **⊗-Bousfield localizations** in some references, reflecting the fact that they are precisely the Bousfield localizations whose class of local equivalences is closed under $- \otimes X$ for every $X \in \mathcal{D}$.

Proposition 2.1.3 ([Rob15, Proposition 2.9],[AI25, p. 1.2.2]). *There exists a symmetric monoidal Bousfield localization*

$$(-)[T^{-1}]\colon \mathsf{Mod}_{\mathcal{C}}(\mathsf{Pr}^L) \to \mathsf{Mod}_{\mathcal{C}}(\mathsf{Pr}^L).$$

For a $\mathcal{C}$-module $\mathcal{D}$, we refer to $\mathcal{D}[T^{-1}]$ as the **formal inversion** of T in $\mathcal{D}$.

***Remark* 2.1.4.** Since the localization $(-)[T^{-1}]$ is symmetric monoidal, the unit map $u : \mathcal{C} \to \mathcal{C}[T^{-1}]$ exhibits $\mathcal{C}[T^{-1}]$ as an idempotent in $\mathsf{Mod}_{\mathcal{C}}(\mathsf{Pr}^L)$, and thus u induces a symmetric monoidal structure on $\mathcal{C}[T^{-1}]$, which in turn induces an equivalence

$$\mathsf{Mod}_{\mathcal{C}[T^{-1}]}(\mathsf{Pr}^L) \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathsf{Mod}_{\mathcal{C}}(\mathsf{Pr}^L)[T^{-1}].$$

This motivates the following abstract definition.

Definition 2.1.5. The **motivic stable homotopy category** is the formal inversion of $\mathbb{T}_S$ in $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$:

$$\mathsf{SH}(S) \coloneqq \mathsf{H}_*(S)\left[\mathbb{T}_S^{-1}\right].$$

This definition is, however, too abstract to have geometric intuition; we need a concrete model of the localization $(-)[\mathbb{T}_S^{-1}]$.

$$\begin{tikzcd}
 & \mathcal{C}[T^{-1}] \arrow[d, "\simeq"] \\
\mathcal{C} \arrow[ur, "\text{formal inversion}"] \arrow[r, "\mathbb{F}"] \arrow[dr, "\mathbb{N}"'] & \mathsf{Sp}_T(\mathcal{C}) \arrow[d, "\simeq \text{when } T \text{ is symmetric}"] \\
 & \mathsf{Tel}_T(\mathcal{C})
\end{tikzcd}$$

Here $\mathbb{F}$ refers to the free model via symmetric sequences (§ 2.1.3), and $\mathbb{N}$ refers to the telescope construction; the two agree when T is symmetric, see Proposition 2.1.16.

2.1.2. *Symmetric sequences and free algebras*

Definition 2.1.6 (Symmetric sequences)**.** Let $\mathbb{F} = \mathsf{Fin}^{\simeq}$ denote the groupoid of finite sets and bijections. For $\mathcal{C} \in \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{Pr}^L)$, the category of **symmetric sequences** in $\mathcal{C}$ is

$$\mathsf{SSeq}(\mathcal{C}) \coloneqq \mathsf{Fun}(\mathbb{F}, \mathcal{C}),$$

equipped with the Day convolution symmetric monoidal structure induced by the disjoint-union monoidal structure on $\mathbb{F}$.

In fact, an object in $\mathsf{SSeq}(\mathcal{C})$ is given by a sequence $E_\bullet = (E_0, E_1, \ldots)$ in $\mathcal{C}$ with a Σ_n-action on E_n. For $X_\bullet, Y_\bullet \in \mathsf{SSeq}(\mathcal{C})$, we have a formula

$$(X_\bullet \otimes Y_\bullet)_n = \bigoplus_{p+q=n} \Sigma_{p+q} \otimes_{\Sigma_p \times \Sigma_q} (X_p \otimes Y_q).$$

From this perspective, one obtains several canonical functors:

- $U\colon \mathsf{SSeq}(\mathcal{C}) \to \mathcal{C}$, carrying $X_\bullet$ to X_0.
- $F\colon \mathcal{C} \to \mathsf{SSeq}(\mathcal{C})$, carrying C to $(C, \varnothing, \varnothing, \ldots)$, and left adjoint to U.
- A shift functor $s_-\colon \mathsf{SSeq}(\mathcal{C}) \to \mathsf{SSeq}(\mathcal{C})$, given by
$$(s_- Y)_\bullet \coloneqq (Y_1, Y_2, \ldots).$$
- s_- admits a left adjoint s_+, given by
$$(s_+ Y)_\bullet \coloneqq \big(\varnothing,\ Y_0,\ \ldots,\ \Sigma_n \otimes_{\Sigma_{n-1}} Y_{n-1},\ \ldots\big).$$

***Remark* 2.1.7** (Notation). The notation s_+ (left adjoint, "shift up") and s_- (right adjoint, "shift down") is borrowed from [AI25, p. 1.3.1]. We will see in Lemma 2.1.12 that, after passing to $\mathsf{Sp}_T(\mathcal{C})$, the localized s_- becomes equivalent to $T \otimes -$ and s_+ becomes equivalent to $\mathrm{Map}(T, -)$. Despite this, we will retain the traditional notation σ^∞ and ω^∞ for the resulting suspension spectrum / underlying object adjunction, in line with the analogy with classical spectra; see the discussion after Definition 2.1.11.

Definition 2.1.8 (Symmetric algebra). For $X \in \mathcal{C}$, write

$$\mathrm{Sym}(X) \coloneqq \bigoplus_{n \geq 0} \big(X^{\otimes n}\big)_{h\Sigma_n} \in \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathcal{C})$$

for the symmetric algebra generated by X.

2.1.3. *Lax T-spectra, T-spectra, and T-telescopes*

For $T \in \mathcal{C}$, consider the symmetric sequence

$$T_{\mathrm{sym}} \coloneqq s_+ F(T) = (\varnothing, T, \varnothing, \varnothing, \ldots) \in \mathsf{SSeq}(\mathcal{C}).$$

We may form its symmetric algebra $\mathrm{Sym}(T_{\mathrm{sym}}) \in \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{SSeq}(\mathcal{C}))$.

Definition 2.1.9 (Lax T-spectra). The category of **lax T-spectra** in $\mathcal{C}$ is

$$\mathsf{Sp}_T^{\mathrm{lax}}(\mathcal{C}) \coloneqq \mathsf{Mod}_{\mathrm{Sym}(T_{\mathrm{sym}})}\big(\mathsf{SSeq}(\mathcal{C})\big) \in \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{Pr}^L)_{\mathcal{C}/}.$$

The adjunction (F, U), together with the free-module functor $\mathrm{Sym}(T_{\mathrm{sym}}) \otimes -$, induces an adjunction

$$\begin{tikzcd} \mathcal{C} \arrow[r, shift left, "F_T"] \arrow[r, phantom, "\perp"] & \mathsf{Sp}_T^{\mathrm{lax}}(\mathcal{C}) \arrow[l, shift left, "U"] \end{tikzcd}$$

We may therefore use U to study the structure of $\mathsf{Sp}_T^{\mathrm{lax}}(\mathcal{C})$.

Lemma 2.1.10. *For each $n \geq 0$, $U_n\big(\mathrm{Sym}(T_{\mathrm{sym}})\big) \simeq T^{\otimes n}$.*

Proof. Since $T_{\mathrm{sym}} = s_+F(T)$ is concentrated at level 1, the Day convolution formula forces $T_{\mathrm{sym}}^{\otimes m}$ to be concentrated at level m; hence only the summand $\mathrm{Sym}^n(T_{\mathrm{sym}})$ of $\mathrm{Sym}(T_{\mathrm{sym}})$ contributes at level n, giving

$$U_n\big(\mathrm{Sym}(T_{\mathrm{sym}})\big) \;\simeq\; U_n\big(\mathrm{Sym}^n(s_+F(T))\big) \;\simeq\; \big(\Sigma_n \otimes T^{\otimes n}\big)_{h\Sigma_n}.$$

The Σ_n-action on $\Sigma_n \otimes T^{\otimes n}$ is diagonal, so the homotopy orbit is equivalent to $T^{\otimes n}$. □

This lemma shows that lax T-spectra "see" $T^{\otimes n}$ at level n; consequently, by Bousfield localizing at the relevant bonding maps, we will obtain a concrete model of T-spectra from $\mathsf{Sp}_T^{\mathrm{lax}}(\mathcal{C})$.

Definition 2.1.11 (T-spectra)**.** The category of T**-spectra** in $\mathcal{C}$ is the accessible localization

$$\mathrm{L}_{\mathsf{Sp}} \colon \mathsf{Sp}_T^{\mathrm{lax}}(\mathcal{C}) \to \mathsf{Sp}_T(\mathcal{C}),$$

spanned by lax T-spectra E for which the structure map $E \to (s_-E)^T$ is an equivalence.

More concretely, an object of $\mathsf{Sp}_T(\mathcal{C})$ is a sequence $E_\bullet = (E_0, E_1, \ldots)$ in $\mathcal{C}$ with Σ_n-action on E_n, together with bonding equivalences

$$E_n \xrightarrow{\sim} \underline{\mathrm{Map}}(T, E_{n+1}) \qquad (n \geq 0).$$

By [Lur17, Proposition 4.1.7.4], $\mathsf{Sp}_T(\mathcal{C})$ admits a unique presentably symmetric monoidal structure for which L_{Sp} is symmetric monoidal.

Lemma 2.1.12 ([AI25, p. 1.3.13])**.** *On $\mathsf{Sp}_T(\mathcal{C})$, there are natural equivalences*

$$s_- \;\simeq\; T \otimes -, \qquad \mathrm{L}_{\mathsf{Sp}}\, s_+ \;\simeq\; \underline{\mathrm{Map}}(T, -),$$

and T acts as an equivalence on $\mathsf{Sp}_T(\mathcal{C})$. In particular, $\mathrm{L}_{\mathsf{Sp}}\, s_+$ and s_- are mutually inverse equivalences of $\mathsf{Sp}_T(\mathcal{C})$.

The adjunction $F_T \dashv U$ can be derived to the following adjunction:

$$\begin{tikzcd} \mathcal{C} \arrow[r, shift left, "\sigma^\infty"] \arrow[r, phantom, "\perp"] & \mathsf{Sp}_T(\mathcal{C}) \arrow[l, shift left, "\omega^\infty"] \end{tikzcd}$$

where $\omega^\infty E = E_0$ on the underlying symmetric sequence. The notation is consistent with the analogy with classical spectra: σ^∞ sends an object of $\mathcal{C}$ to its T-suspension spectrum, while ω^∞ extracts the underlying 0-th level. Since T becomes invertible in $\mathsf{Sp}_T(\mathcal{C})$, this adjunction extends naturally: for each $n \in \mathbb{Z}$ one has an adjunction $\sigma^{\infty-n} \dashv \omega^{\infty-n}$, with $\omega^{\infty-n}E$ the "n-th level" of the spectrum.

Corollary 2.1.13 (Explicit description of T-spectra)**.** *The data of an object $E \in \mathsf{Sp}_T(\mathcal{C})$ is equivalent to:*

- *a sequence of objects $\big(E(j)\big)_{j\in\mathbb{Z}}$ in $\mathcal{C}$, with $E(j) := \omega^{\infty-j}E$;*
- *equivalences $E(j) \xrightarrow{\sim} \underline{\mathrm{Map}}(T, E(j+1))$ for every $j \in \mathbb{Z}$.*

A commutative algebra structure on E corresponds further to compatible graded multiplications $E(i) \otimes E(j) \to E(i+j)$.

Proof. The first two clauses follow from Lemma 2.1.12; the multiplicative statement is dealt with in §2.3.1. □

Proposition 2.1.14 (Formal inversion and T-spectra, [AI25, p. 1.3.14])**.** *There is a categorical equivalence*

$$\mathcal{C}[T^{-1}] \simeq \mathsf{Sp}_T(\mathcal{C}).$$

Recall that in stable homotopy theory, stabilisation is realised as a colimit. We now apply the same idea to give a more direct construction of $\mathsf{SH}(S)$: namely, by writing $\mathcal{C}[T^{-1}]$ as a colimit along $T \otimes -$ in $\mathsf{Mod}_{\mathcal{C}}(\mathsf{Pr}^L)$. This construction, however, requires an additional symmetry condition on T; see Proposition 2.1.16.

Definition 2.1.15. The category of T**-telescopes** in $\mathcal{C}$ is given by the following colimit in $\mathsf{Mod}_{\mathcal{C}}(\mathsf{Pr}^L)$:

$$\mathsf{Tel}_T(\mathcal{C}) := \operatorname{colim}\left(\mathcal{C} \xrightarrow{T\otimes -} \mathcal{C} \xrightarrow{T\otimes -} \cdots\right).$$

Proposition 2.1.16 (Telescope comparison, [AI25, p. 1.6.3])**.** *If T is* ***symmetric*** *in the sense that the cyclic permutation*

$$T^{\otimes 3} \longrightarrow T^{\otimes 3}, \qquad a \otimes b \otimes c \longmapsto b \otimes c \otimes a,$$

is homotopic to the identity in $\mathcal{C}$, then there is an equivalence

$$\mathcal{C}[T^{-1}] \simeq \mathsf{Sp}_T(\mathcal{C}) \simeq \mathsf{Tel}_T(\mathcal{C})$$

in $\mathsf{Mod}_{\mathcal{C}}(\mathsf{Pr}^L)$.

2.1.4. *Specialization to motivic homotopy theory*

We now apply the preceding machinery to motivic homotopy theory. The input is the pointed motivic homotopy category $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$ from Chapter 1, equipped with the smash product, and the Tate object $\mathbb{T}_S$.

Proposition 2.1.17 ($\mathbb{T}_S$ is symmetric)**.** *The cyclic permutation $\sigma\colon \mathbb{T}_S^{\wedge 3} \to \mathbb{T}_S^{\wedge 3}$ is $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopic to the identity in $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$.*

Proof. By Proposition 1.4.4, $\mathbb{T}_S \simeq \mathbb{P}^1_S$. It suffices to show that a transposition on $\mathbb{P}^1 \wedge \mathbb{P}^1$ is $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopic to $-\mathrm{id}$, since a 3-cycle in Σ_3 is a composite of two transpositions and acts as $(-\mathrm{id})^2 = \mathrm{id}$.

Consider the action of $\mathrm{SL}_2(\mathbb{Z})$ on $\mathbb{P}^1 \wedge \mathbb{P}^1$ via its action on the two factors. Set

$$A := \begin{bmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ -1 & 0 \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{bmatrix}\begin{bmatrix} -1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Then $A \in \mathrm{SL}_2(\mathbb{Z})$ factors as a product of elementary matrices, and elementary matrices are $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopic to the identity via $\begin{bmatrix} 1 & t \\ 0 & 1 \end{bmatrix}$, $t \in \mathbb{A}^1$. Therefore A is $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopic to the identity, which gives

$$\begin{bmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{bmatrix} \simeq \begin{bmatrix} -1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Hence the transposition τ on $\mathbb{P}^1 \wedge \mathbb{P}^1$ is $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopic to $(-\mathrm{id}) \wedge \mathrm{id} = -\mathrm{id}$. □

Corollary 2.1.18 (Telescope model of $\mathsf{SH}(S)$)**.** *Applying Proposition 2.1.16 to* $(\mathsf{H}_*(S), \mathbb{T}_S)$ *yields*

$$\mathsf{SH}(S) \simeq \operatorname{colim}\left(\mathsf{H}_*(S) \xrightarrow{-\wedge \mathbb{T}_S} \mathsf{H}_*(S) \xrightarrow{-\wedge \mathbb{T}_S} \cdots\right)$$

in $\mathsf{Mod}_{\mathsf{H}_*(S)}(\mathsf{Pr}^L)$.

Terminology 2.1.19. Objects of $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ are called **($\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant) motivic spectra**.

Proposition 2.1.20 (Functoriality of SH). *The assignments $S \mapsto \mathsf{SH}(S)$ and $(f\colon T \to S) \mapsto (f^*\colon \mathsf{SH}(S) \to \mathsf{SH}(T))$, where f^* is the symmetric monoidal pullback, define a functor*

$$\mathsf{SH}\colon (\mathsf{Sch}^{\mathrm{qcqs}})^{\mathrm{op}} \longrightarrow \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{Pr}^L_{\mathrm{st}}).$$

Stability follows from $\mathbb{T}_S \simeq S^1 \wedge \mathbb{G}_m$: inverting $\mathbb{T}_S$ inverts the simplicial S^1, hence $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ is stable.

Putting together all the constructions from Chapter 1 and this section, the motivic spectrum functor $M_S\colon \mathsf{Sm}_S \to \mathsf{SH}(S)$ factors as the composite

$$\mathsf{Sm}_S \xrightarrow{よ} \mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S) \xrightarrow{\mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{mot}}} \mathsf{H}(S) \xrightarrow{(-)_+} \mathsf{H}_*(S) \xrightarrow{\sigma^\infty_{\mathbb{T}_S}} \mathsf{SH}(S),$$

where each step realises a universal property:

- よ: free cocompletion;
- $\mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{mot}}$: free imposition of Nisnevich descent and $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariance;
- $(-)_+$: free adjunction of a basepoint;
- $\sigma^\infty_{\mathbb{T}_S}$: free $\otimes$-inversion of $\mathbb{T}_S$ (Definition 2.1.5).

Concretely, $M_S(X) = \sigma^\infty_{\mathbb{T}_S}\big(\mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{mot}}(X)_+\big)$ for $X \in \mathsf{Sm}_S$. The subscript $\mathbb{T}_S$ distinguishes this one-step passage from $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$ to $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ from the generic formal-inversion functor σ^∞ of §2.1.3 and from the simplicial-suspension functor Σ^∞ introduced below.

***Remark* 2.1.21.** Since every step can be upgraded to a symmetric monoidal functor, we have $M_S(S) \simeq \mathbf{1}_S \in \mathsf{SH}(S)$ and $M_S(X \times_S Y) \simeq M_S(X) \otimes M_S(Y)$.

One also has the following properties:

- the map $M_S(\mathbb{A}^1) \to M_S(S)$ induced by $\mathbb{A}^1 \to S$ is an equivalence;
- the Tate motive $\mathbb{T}_S$ is the cofiber of $M_S(S) \xrightarrow{\infty} M_S(\mathbb{P}^1_S)$, and is invertible by construction;
- M_S carries Nisnevich distinguished squares in Sm_S to cartesian squares in $\mathsf{SH}(S)$.

From the construction above, $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ is the initial presentably symmetric monoidal stable category satisfying the properties above.

Recall from Definition 1.4.3 that there are two types of "circles" in $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$. After stabilisation the simplicial circle becomes the categorical suspension $[1]$, computed by the pushout

$$\begin{tikzcd} E \arrow[r] \arrow[d] \arrow[dr, phantom, "\ulcorner"] & 0 \arrow[d] \\ 0 \arrow[r] & E[1]. \end{tikzcd}$$

Combined with the unstable identity $\mathbb{T}_S \simeq S^1 \wedge \mathbb{G}_m$ in $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$, the bigraded sphere $S^{i,j} \in \mathsf{SH}(S)$ can therefore be expressed as

$$S^{i,j} \;\simeq\; \mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes j}[i-2j],$$

and for any $E \in \mathsf{SH}(S)$ we write $\Sigma^{i,j}E \coloneqq E \otimes S^{i,j}$.

Instead of inverting $\mathbb{T}_S$ in a single step, one may first stabilise $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$ with respect to the simplicial circle S^1. This produces the category of $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant Nisnevich sheaves of spectra

$$\mathsf{Sp}(\mathsf{H}_*(S)) \simeq \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp}),$$

together with the simplicial suspension functor $\Sigma^\infty \colon \mathsf{H}_*(S) \to \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$. Since S^1 is already invertible in $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$, inverting $\mathbb{T}_S$ there is equivalent to inverting $\mathbb{G}_m$; write

$$\sigma^\infty \colon \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp}) \longrightarrow \mathsf{SH}(S)$$

for the resulting formal-inversion functor, and ω^∞ for its right adjoint. We then have the factorisation

$$\sigma^\infty_{\mathbb{T}_S} \simeq \sigma^\infty \circ \Sigma^\infty \colon \mathsf{H}_*(S) \longrightarrow \mathsf{SH}(S),$$

and the identification $\mathsf{SH}(S) \simeq \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})[\mathbb{G}_m^{-1}]$ [ABH26, p. 2.2.3]. The lax symmetric monoidal right adjoint

$$\omega^\infty \colon \mathsf{SH}(S) \longrightarrow \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$$

is explicitly described by $\omega^\infty(E) = \mathrm{map}_{\mathsf{SH}(S)}(M_S(-), E)$.

***Remark* 2.1.22.** Objects of $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$ are also known as **motivic S^1-spectra**, and this category is sometimes denoted $\mathsf{SH}^{S^1}(S)$; we will not use this alternative notation.

2.2. The Six-Functor Formalism on SH

Having constructed SH as a functor $(\mathsf{Sch}^{\mathrm{qcqs}})^{\mathrm{op}} \to \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{Pr}^L_{\mathrm{st}})$, we now extend it to a full six-functor formalism. The modern way to package such a formalism is through span categories, so we begin by recording that framework in §2.2.1. The remaining subsections then apply it to SH: we introduce the cdh topology (§2.2.2), verify the localization axiom and base-change properties (§2.2.3), assemble the six-functor formalism for SH (§2.2.4), deduce cdh descent as a corollary, and finally revisit the universal property of SH in its precise Drew–Gallauer form (§2.2.5).

2.2.1. Span categories and suitable decompositions

Classically, a six-functor formalism on a category $\mathcal{C}$ of geometric objects is a packet of data $(f^*, f_*, f_!, f^!, \otimes, \underline{\mathrm{Map}})$ subject to an intricate web of adjunctions, base change isomorphisms, and projection formulae. Even writing down this data in a fully coherent categorical sense is a non-trivial task.

A far more economical description was initiated by Liu–Zheng [LZ24], and brought to its present form by Mann [Man22] and Scholze [Sch26]. Given a wide subcategory $E \subset \mathcal{C}$ closed under composition and base change, one forms the **span category** $\mathsf{Span}(\mathcal{C}, E)$: its objects are those of $\mathcal{C}$, and its morphisms $X \to Y$ are spans

$$X \leftarrow Z \xrightarrow{e} Y, \qquad e \in E,$$

composed by pullback. When $\mathcal{C}$ has finite products, $\mathsf{Span}(\mathcal{C}, E)$ inherits a symmetric monoidal structure. In this language, a **three-functor formalism** on $(\mathcal{C}, E)$ is a lax symmetric monoidal functor

$$\mathsf{D} \colon \mathsf{Span}(\mathcal{C}, E) \longrightarrow \mathsf{Cat},$$

which encodes f^* (backward legs), $f_!$ (forward legs), and $\otimes$ (monoidal structure) in a single coherent package. The remaining three operations f_*, $f^!$, $\underline{\mathrm{Map}}$ are then obtained as right adjoints, and are therefore *properties* of D rather than additional structure.

The challenge is that constructing a lax monoidal functor out of $\mathsf{Span}(C, E)$ directly is difficult. In practice, one starts from a much simpler piece of data, namely a functor

$$\mathsf{D}_0 \colon C^{\mathrm{op}} \longrightarrow \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{Cat})$$

encoding only f^* and $\otimes$, and asks when it extends to $\mathsf{Span}(C, E)$. The key input is a **suitable decomposition** of E in the sense of Mann [Man22, Definition A.5.9]: a pair of wide subcategories $I, P \subset E$ (thought of as "étale-like" and "proper-like" morphisms respectively) such that every $e \in E$ factors as $e = p \circ i$ with $i \in I$ and $p \in P$, subject to mild cancellation and truncation axioms. The extension theorem then reads: if $i^* = \mathsf{D}_0(i)$ admits a left adjoint $i_\sharp$ and $p^* = \mathsf{D}_0(p)$ admits a right adjoint p_* satisfying the expected base change and projection formulae—in particular the mixed Beck–Chevalley equivalence $i_\sharp p'_* \simeq p_* i'_\sharp$—then D_0 admits an essentially unique extension to a three-functor formalism D, in which

$$f_! = p_* \, i_\sharp \qquad \text{for any factorization } f = p \circ i.$$

Recently, Cnossen–Lenz–Linskens [CLL25] gave a conceptually streamlined account of this extension theorem. They enhance $\mathsf{Span}(C, E)$ to a 2-category whose 2-morphisms encode the adjunction data of $i_\sharp$ and p_* in a fully coherent way, and they prove that the inclusion $C^{\mathrm{op}} \hookrightarrow \mathsf{Span}_2(C, E)_{I,P}$ is a universal (I, P)-biadjointable functor. In this setup, Mann's extension theorem becomes a formal corollary; as a byproduct, the unit and counit witnessing $i_\sharp \dashv i^*$ are part of the structure of D, rather than non-canonical choices recoverable only after the fact.

Construction 2.2.1 (CLL 2-categorical span category)**.** The 2-category $\mathsf{Span}_2(C, E)_{I,P}$ has:

- *objects:* objects in C;
- 1-*morphisms* $X \to Z$: spans

$$\begin{tikzcd} & Y \arrow[dl, "f"'] \arrow[dr, "g"] & \\ X & & Z \end{tikzcd}$$

  with $g \in E$;
- 2-*morphisms* between two such spans: diagrams

$$\begin{tikzcd} & Y & \\ X & Y'' \arrow[u, "a"] \arrow[d, "b"'] & Z \\ & Y' \arrow[ul] \arrow[ur] & \end{tikzcd}$$

  with $a \in P$ and $b \in I$.

Theorem 2.2.2 ([CLL25, Theorem 5.17])**.** *Assume $I, P \subseteq E \subseteq C$ are wide subcategories closed under base change, every map in E factors as $p \circ i$ with $p \in P$ and $i \in I$, and maps in $I \cap P$ are truncated. Then the inclusion*

$$C^{\mathrm{op}} \hookrightarrow \mathsf{Span}_2(C, E)_{I,P}$$

is the initial functor under which I satisfies left base change (Definition 2.2.17) and P satisfies right base change; equivalently, it is the universal (I, P)-biadjointable functor.

Sketch of proof. The argument proceeds in three steps.

Step 1. One verifies directly that the inclusion $\mathcal{C}^{\mathrm{op}} \hookrightarrow \mathsf{Span}_2(\mathcal{C}, E)_{I,P}$ is (I, P)-biadjointable, so that it is a candidate for the universal functor.

Step 2. Formal 2-categorical arguments produce an abstract initial (I, P)-biadjointable 2-category $\mathbb{B}(\mathcal{C}; I, P)$ together with a comparison functor

$$\mathbb{B}(\mathcal{C}; I, P) \longrightarrow \mathsf{Span}_2(\mathcal{C}, E)_{I,P}.$$

This functor is essentially surjective on objects and 1-morphisms, so one reduces to checking that it induces equivalences on Hom-categories.

Step 3. The Hom-category comparison reduces in turn to identifying the *free* (I, P)-biadjointable functor, which is computed explicitly as

$$Y \longmapsto \mathsf{Span}\big(E_{/Y},\ P,\ I\big),$$

i.e. the span category of E-morphisms into Y, with legs of type P and I respectively. This identification completes the proof.

□

Thus, to construct a six-functor formalism it suffices to verify the three biadjointability conditions: left base change for I, right base change for P, and the mixed Beck–Chevalley equivalence. All coherences come for free from the universal property.

This is the framework in which we place SH. Taking $\mathcal{C} = \mathsf{Sch}^{\mathrm{qcqs}}$, E = morphisms locally of finite presentation, I = open immersions, P = proper morphisms, the six-functor formalism on SH will be obtained by verifying that $f^*\colon \mathsf{SH}(X) \to \mathsf{SH}(Y)$ and the smash product satisfy precisely these hypotheses. The deep input—smooth base change and proper base change for SH—is classical work of Morel–Voevodsky [MV99] and Ayoub [Ayo07] / Cisinski–Déglise [CD19]; the verification is carried out in §2.2.3–§2.2.4 below, and the extension to the full six-functor package is then formal.

2.2.2. *cdh topology*

Abstract blowup squares

Definition 2.2.3 (Abstract blowup square)**.** A commutative diagram in Sch_S

$$\begin{tikzcd} E \arrow[r] \arrow[d, "q"'] \arrow[dr, phantom, "\lrcorner", very near start] & \tilde{X} \arrow[d, "p"] \\ Z \arrow[r, hook, "i"'] & X \end{tikzcd}$$

is an **abstract blowup square** if

- i is a closed immersion;
- p is proper;
- p induces an isomorphism $p^{-1}(X \setminus Z)_{\mathrm{red}} \xrightarrow{\sim} (X \setminus Z)_{\mathrm{red}}$;
- $E = \tilde{X} \times_X Z$ (as a reduced scheme).

***Remark* 2.2.4** (Comparison with Nisnevich squares)**.** Abstract blowup squares are structurally parallel to Nisnevich squares:

	Nisnevich square	**Abstract blowup square**
Decomposition of X	$U \overset{\text{open}}{\hookrightarrow} X$	$Z \overset{\text{closed}}{\hookrightarrow} X$
Covering morphism	$V \to X$ étale	$\tilde{X} \to X$ proper
Isomorphism away from	$X \setminus U$	$X \setminus Z$
Typical source	étale neighborhoods	Blowups, normalizations

Both decompose X into a known part and a part needing coverage, then handle the latter via the appropriate class of morphisms.

Example 2.2.5 (cdh cover of the nodal curve)**.** For the nodal curve N with $\mathrm{char}(k) \neq 2$:

$$\begin{tikzcd} E \arrow[r] \arrow[d] \arrow[dr, phantom, "\lrcorner", very near start] & \tilde{N} \simeq \mathbb{A}^1 \arrow[d, "p"] \\ Z = \{0\} \arrow[r, hook] & N, \end{tikzcd}$$

where p is the normalization (finite, hence proper) and $E = \mathrm{Spec}(k[c]/(c^2 - 1)) \simeq \mathrm{Spec}(k) \sqcup \mathrm{Spec}(k)$ encodes the two tangent directions at the node. For a cdh sheaf $\mathcal{F}$,

$$\mathcal{F}(N) \simeq \mathcal{F}(\mathbb{A}^1) \times_{\mathcal{F}(\{c=1\} \sqcup \{c=-1\})} \mathcal{F}(\{0\}).$$

Thus invariants of the singular curve N are completely determined by their values on the smooth model $\mathbb{A}^1$, the singular point $\{0\}$, and the gluing data over E.

Definition of the cdh topology

Definition 2.2.6 (cdh topology)**.** For X qcqs, the **cdh topology** on $\mathsf{Sch}_X^{\mathrm{qcqs}}$ is the Grothendieck topology generated by

(i) Nisnevich squares (Definition 1.1.6), and

(ii) abstract blowup squares (Definition 2.2.3).

A presheaf $\mathcal{F}$ on $\mathsf{Sch}_X^{\mathrm{qcqs}}$ is a **cdh sheaf** if it sends both types of squares to pullback squares—equivalently, satisfies both Nisnevich excision and proper excision.

Cohomological dimension of the Nisnevich and cdh topoi

A foundational structural result about the Nisnevich topology is a sharp bound on the homotopy dimension of its associated topos. Recall that a topos $\mathcal{X}$ has **homotopy dimension** $\leq d$ if every $(d-1)$-connected sheaf on $\mathcal{X}$ admits a global section. Equivalently, sheaves of n-truncated anima "can be controlled" once $n \geq d$.

Theorem 2.2.7 (Clausen–Mathew)**.** *For any qcqs scheme X of finite Krull dimension,*

$$\dim \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis}}(\mathsf{Et}_X) \;\leq\; \mathrm{Kr.dim}(X),$$

where the left-hand side denotes the homotopy dimension of the Nisnevich topos on the small étale site of X, and $\mathrm{Kr.dim}(X)$ is the Krull dimension.

***Remark* 2.2.8** (Geometric characterization of Nisnevich-local schemes)**.** A qcqs scheme X has no non-trivial Nisnevich coverings if and only if X is henselian local. This explains why Nisnevich stalks are computed at henselian local rings: the strict henselization $\mathcal{O}^h_{X,x}$ at a point $x \in X$ realizes the Nisnevich-local model of an étale neighborhood of x. Combined with Theorem 2.2.7, this gives a tight geometric grip on $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis}}$: sheaves are determined by their values on henselian local rings, and the Postnikov tower converges in finite Krull dimension.

This is a far-reaching generalization of the classical fact, due to Grothendieck and Kato–Saito, that Nisnevich cohomology vanishes above the Krull dimension. The categorical reformulation given by Clausen–Mathew is more powerful: it controls not only cohomology groups but also the truncation behavior of arbitrary sheaves of anima. In particular, on a finite-dimensional scheme, every Nisnevich sheaf of spectra is hypercomplete, and every Postnikov tower converges.

***Remark* 2.2.9** (Comparison with étale and Zariski)**.** The bound in Theorem 2.2.7 is sharp and reflects another structural advantage of the Nisnevich topology over its neighbors:

- **Zariski:** $\dim \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Zar}}(X) \leq \mathrm{Kr.dim}(X)$ as well, but the Zariski topology is too coarse for many cohomology theories (e.g., it does not see Galois descent).
- **étale:** no such finite bound holds in general; the étale topos can have infinite cohomological dimension (e.g., for $\mathrm{Spec}(k)$ with k a field of positive characteristic and large absolute Galois group).

The Nisnevich topology thus combines the dimensional finiteness of Zariski with enough geometric refinement to support algebraic K-theory and motivic constructions.

Just as the Nisnevich topos has homotopy dimension bounded by the Krull dimension (Theorem 2.2.7), the cdh topos admits a parallel bound, this time in terms of the valuation dimension. Recall:

Definition 2.2.10 (Valuation dimension)**.** The **valuation dimension** $\mathrm{v.dim}(X)$ of a qcqs scheme X is defined by $\mathrm{v.dim}(X) \leq d$ if and only if for every integral affine subscheme $\mathrm{Spec}(A) \subseteq X$ and every chain

$$A \subseteq V_0 \subseteq V_1 \subseteq \cdots \subseteq V_n \subseteq \mathrm{Frac}(A)$$

of valuation subrings of the fraction field with strict inclusions, one has $n \leq d$.

The valuation dimension always satisfies $\mathrm{v.dim}(X) \geq \mathrm{Kr.dim}(X)$, with equality when X is Noetherian. The two notions coincide on most schemes one encounters in practice.

Theorem 2.2.11 (Elmanto–Hoyois–Iwasa–Kelly)**.** *For any qcqs scheme X,*

$$\dim \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{cdh}}(\mathsf{Sch}^{\mathrm{fp}}_X) \;\leq\; \mathrm{v.dim}(X),$$

where the left-hand side is the homotopy dimension of the cdh topos on the category of finitely presented X-schemes.

***Remark* 2.2.12** (Geometric characterization of cdh-local schemes)**.** Parallel to the Nisnevich case (Remark 2.2.8): a qcqs scheme X has no non-trivial cdh coverings if and only if every valuation ring of the function fields of X is henselian (one says X is *valuatively henselian* or that X is a *henselian valuation scheme*). Cdh stalks are accordingly computed at henselian valuation rings, and the dimensional bound of Theorem 2.2.11 measures the depth of these stalks via the valuation chain length.

***Remark* 2.2.13** (Why valuation dimension?). The cdh topology is sensitive to phenomena invisible to the Nisnevich topology—namely, those involving non-Noetherian behavior such as the structure of valuation rings of fraction fields. The valuation dimension captures exactly the right invariant. Two key consequences:

(i) **$\mathbb{A}^1$-stability:** $\mathrm{v.dim}(X \times \mathbb{A}^n) = \mathrm{v.dim}(X) + n$, mirroring the analogous Krull dimension formula but more robustly behaved on non-Noetherian schemes.

(ii) **Coincidence with Krull dimension:** $\mathrm{v.dim}(X) = \mathrm{Kr.dim}(X)$ when X is Noetherian, or more generally a valuation ring.

On Noetherian schemes, Theorem 2.2.11 thus specializes to a Krull-dimensional bound, paralleling the Clausen–Mathew result for the Nisnevich topos. The genuinely new content is the extension to non-Noetherian schemes via valuation theory.

***Remark* 2.2.14** (Significance for motivic cohomology). The bound in Theorem 2.2.11 is the key technical input for many recent advances in motivic cohomology over singular and non-Noetherian bases, including the construction of motivic cohomology of arbitrary qcqs schemes by Elmanto–Morrow [EM23], and the comparison with prismatic cohomology in Bachmann–Elmanto–Morrow [BEM25]. Without dimensional finiteness, Postnikov towers in the cdh topos would not converge, and the cdh-local replacement of motivic invariants would be intractable.

***Remark* 2.2.15** (Finitarity). The Nisnevich and cdh topologies are both *finitary*: every covering family may be refined to a finite subcover. This is essential for several compatibility results we will use:

- Nisnevich and cdh sheafification commute with filtered colimits.
- The topoi $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis}}(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$ and $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{cdh}}(\mathsf{Sch}_S^{\mathrm{fp}})$ are compactly generated, with compact generators given by the (sheafifications of) representables.
- Hypercompletion behaves well, and on finite-dimensional schemes coincides with the topos itself by Theorem 2.2.7 and Theorem 2.2.11.

2.2.3. Localization and base change

Definition 2.2.16 (Localization axiom). A functor $\mathsf{D}\colon (\mathsf{Sch}^{\mathrm{qcqs}})^{\mathrm{op}} \to \mathsf{Cat}_{\mathrm{st}}$ satisfies the **localization axiom** if for every $X \in \mathsf{Sch}^{\mathrm{qcqs}}$, every closed immersion $i\colon Z \hookrightarrow X$ with open complement $j\colon U \hookrightarrow X$ gives rise to a recollement

$$\begin{tikzcd} \mathsf{D}(Z) \arrow[r, "i_*"] & \mathsf{D}(X) \arrow[l, bend right, "i^*"'] \arrow[l, bend left, "i^!"] \arrow[r, "j^*"] & \mathsf{D}(U) \arrow[l, bend right, "j_!"'] \arrow[l, bend left, "j_*"] \end{tikzcd}$$

of stable ∞-categories. That is, the pair (i^*, j^*) is jointly conservative, and both i_* and j_* are fully faithful.

Definition 2.2.17 (Base change properties). Let $\mathsf{D}\colon (\mathsf{Sch}^{\mathrm{qcqs}})^{\mathrm{op}} \to \mathsf{Cat}_{\mathrm{st}}$ be a functor.

- A morphism $g\colon C \to D$ satisfies **left base change** if for every pullback square

$$\begin{tikzcd} A \arrow[r, "k"] \arrow[d, "h"'] \arrow[dr, phantom, "\lrcorner", very near start] & B \arrow[d, "f"] \\ C \arrow[r, "g"'] & D \end{tikzcd}$$

the functor $k^*\colon \mathsf{D}(B) \to \mathsf{D}(A)$ admits a left adjoint $k_\sharp$, and the canonical morphism $k_\sharp h^* \to f^* g_\sharp$ is an equivalence.

- A morphism $f\colon B \to D$ satisfies **right base change** if for every pullback square as above, $h^*\colon \mathsf{D}(C) \to \mathsf{D}(A)$ admits a right adjoint h_*, and the canonical morphism $g^* f_* \to h_* k^*$ is an equivalence.

From the localization axiom together with base change for I and P, one deduces descent for D:

Proposition 2.2.18. *Let* $\mathsf{D}\colon (\mathsf{Sch}^{\mathrm{qcqs}})^{\mathrm{op}} \to \mathsf{Cat}_{\mathrm{st}}$ *satisfy the localization axiom.*

(i) If every étale morphism satisfies left base change, then D *satisfies Nisnevich descent.*

(ii) If every finitely presented proper morphism satisfies right base change, then D *satisfies abstract blowup descent.*

Proof. We treat abstract blowup descent; the Nisnevich case is similar (and dual). Consider an abstract blowup square

$$\begin{tikzcd} E \arrow[r, "k"] \arrow[d, "q"'] \arrow[dr, phantom, "\lrcorner"] & \tilde{X} \arrow[d, "p"] \\ Z \arrow[r, hook, "i"'] & X. \end{tikzcd}$$

By assumption, p^* and q^* admit right adjoints p_* and q_*. We must show that the comparison functor

$$(p^*, i^*)\colon \mathsf{D}(X) \longrightarrow \mathsf{D}(\tilde{X}) \times_{\mathsf{D}(E)} \mathsf{D}(Z)$$

is an equivalence. Its right adjoint G sends a pair (A, B) with common image $C \in \mathsf{D}(E)$ to the fiber product

$$G(A, B) \;=\; p_* A \times_{(iq)_* C} i_* B.$$

Conservativity of (p^*, i^*). By the localization axiom, (i^*, j^*) is jointly conservative, where $j\colon U = X \setminus Z \hookrightarrow X$. Since p restricts to an isomorphism over U, we have $j^* \simeq h^* p^*$ (with $h\colon U \hookrightarrow \tilde{X}$ the open complement of k), so (p^*, i^*) is also jointly conservative.

Counit is an equivalence. It remains to show that for every (A, B), the counit $(p^*, i^*) \circ G(A, B) \to (A, B)$ is an equivalence. We verify the two components separately.

(i^*-component.) Since i is a closed immersion, i_* is fully faithful by the localization axiom, so $i^* i_* \simeq \mathrm{id}$. Combined with right base change for p along i, which gives $i^* p_* A \simeq q_* k^* A \simeq q_* C$, the fiber product becomes

$$i^*(p_* A \times_{(iq)_* C} i_* B) \;\simeq\; q_* C \times_{q_* C} B \;\simeq\; B.$$

(p^*-component.) We must show $p^*(p_* A \times_{(iq)_* C} i_* B) \xrightarrow{\sim} A$. By the localization axiom, (k^*, h^*) is jointly conservative on $\mathsf{D}(\tilde{X})$, so it suffices to check after applying each.

Applying k^*: using $k^* p^* = q^* i^*$ and the previous case,

$$k^* p^*(p_* A \times_{(iq)_* C} i_* B) \;\simeq\; q^* B \;\simeq\; C \;\simeq\; k^* A.$$

Applying h^*: since $i_* B$ and $(iq)_* C$ are supported on Z, applying $j^* = h^* p^*$ kills them, leaving $j^* p_* A$. We must show $j^* p_* A \simeq h^* A$. Consider the diagram of fiber sequences supplied by the localization axiom:

$$\begin{tikzcd} i_* i^! p_* A \arrow[r] \arrow[d] & p_* A \arrow[r] \arrow[d, equal] & j_* j^* p_* A \arrow[d] \\ p_* k_* k^! A \arrow[r] & p_* A \arrow[r] & p_* h_* h^* A. \end{tikzcd}$$

The left vertical arrow is an equivalence by right base change for i along p, and the middle arrow is the identity, hence the right vertical arrow is also an equivalence. Since $ph = j$ we have $p_* h_* = j_*$; because j_* is fully faithful, this gives $j^* p_* A \simeq h^* A$. □

2.2.4. *The six-functor formalism for* SH

We now apply the framework of §2.2.1 to SH. The geometric input is the localization axiom together with base change for étale and proper morphisms.

Theorem 2.2.19 (Morel–Voevodsky [MV99]). *The stable motivic functor* $\mathsf{SH}\colon (\mathsf{Sch}^{\mathrm{qcqs}})^{\mathrm{op}} \to \mathsf{Pr}^L_{\mathrm{st}}$ *satisfies the localization axiom.*

Theorem 2.2.20 (Ayoub [Ayo07], Cisinski–Déglise [CD19], Cnossen–Lenz–Linskens [CLL25]). *There is an essentially unique lax symmetric monoidal extension making the following diagram commute:*

$$\begin{tikzcd} (\mathsf{Sch}^{\mathrm{qcqs}})^{\mathrm{op}} \arrow[r, "\mathsf{SH}"] \arrow[d, hook] & \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{Pr}^L_{\mathrm{st}}) \\ \mathsf{Span}_2\big(\mathsf{Sch}^{\mathrm{qcqs}}, E\big)^{\otimes}_{I,P} \arrow[ur, dashed] & \end{tikzcd}$$

with E = morphisms locally of finite presentation, I = open immersions, and P = proper morphisms. Explicitly, $\mathsf{Span}_2(\mathsf{Sch}^{\mathrm{qcqs}}, E)_{I,P}$ *has:*

- objects: *quasi-compact quasi-separated schemes;*
- 1-morphisms $X \to Z$: *spans*

$$\begin{tikzcd} & Y \arrow[dl, "f"'] \arrow[dr, "g"] & \\ X & & Z \end{tikzcd}$$

  with g locally of finite presentation;

- 2-morphisms *between two such spans: diagrams*

$$\begin{tikzcd} & Y & \\ X & Y'' \arrow[u, "a"] \arrow[d, "b"] & Z \\ & Y' \arrow[ul] \arrow[ur] & \end{tikzcd}$$

  with a proper and b an open immersion.

In this extension, the ***exceptional pushforward*** *along $f \in E$ is given by $f_! = p_* i_\sharp$ for any factorization $f = p \circ i$ with i an open immersion and p proper.*

***Remark* 2.2.21** (Structure of the proof). The proof decomposes into a formal step and a deep geometric step.

The *formal step* is the universal property of $\mathsf{Span}_2(-, E)^{\otimes}_{I,P}$ (Theorem 2.2.2): given any lax symmetric monoidal functor $\mathsf{D}_0\colon (C^{\times})^{\mathrm{op}} \to \mathsf{Cat}^{\times}$ which is (I, P)-biadjointable and satisfies

the projection formula, there is an essentially unique extension to $\mathsf{Span}_2(\mathcal{C}, E)^{\otimes}_{I,P}$. This step is purely 2-categorical and contains no algebro-geometric content.

The *geometric step* is to verify the input hypothesis, namely that SH is (I, P)-biadjointable. This breaks further into three ingredients:

- **Smooth/étale base change and the projection formula for $i_\sharp$**: these follow essentially from the construction of SH. The smooth pushforward $i_\sharp$ on $\mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_-)$ is computed via restriction along $\mathsf{Sm}_{/T} \to \mathsf{Sm}_{/S}$ for $i\colon T \to S$ étale, and this is compatible with base change at the level of presheaves.
- **Localization**: the recollement (i^*, j^*) for closed immersions i with open complement j, i.e. Theorem 2.2.19.
- **Proper base change and the projection formula for p_***: this is the deep input. Ayoub [Ayo07] proved proper base change for projective morphisms; combined with localization [MV99], this yields proper base change for projective morphisms in full generality. Cisinski–Déglise [CD19] extended this to arbitrary proper morphisms using Chow's lemma and a Noetherian approximation argument.

Once all three ingredients are in hand, the full six-functor package on SH follows by invoking the universal property (Theorem 2.2.2). The mixed Beck–Chevalley equivalence $i_\sharp p'_* \simeq p_* i'_\sharp$ is not an additional input: it follows from proper base change applied to a pullback square one of whose edges is an étale morphism.

By Proposition 2.2.18 together with Theorem 2.2.19 and the proper base change ingredient of Remark 2.2.21, we obtain:

Corollary 2.2.22. *The functor* SH *is a cdh sheaf.*

2.2.5. *The Drew–Gallauer universal property*

With the six-functor formalism on SH now in hand, we return to the question advertised in the chapter introduction: in what precise sense is SH universal? The following theorem of Drew–Gallauer supplies the answer, and identifies the three axioms that single out SH among all reasonable $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant six-functor formalisms.

Theorem 2.2.23 (Drew–Gallauer [DG22]; cf. [Sch26, Theorem 11.1])**.** *Let k be a noetherian base ring with $\mathrm{Spec}(k)$ of finite Krull dimension, and let $\mathcal{C}$ be the category of separated finite-type k-schemes, equipped with I = open immersions and P = proper morphisms. Consider the category of presentable six-functor formalisms*

$$\mathsf{D}\colon \mathsf{Corr}(\mathcal{C}) \longrightarrow \mathsf{Pr}^L_{\mathrm{st}}$$

in which open immersions are cohomologically étale, proper maps are cohomologically proper, and which satisfy:

(i) ***Cohomological smoothness:*** *every smooth morphism is cohomologically smooth in* D*;*

(ii) ***Excision:*** *for any closed immersion $i\colon Z \hookrightarrow X$ with open complement $j\colon U \hookrightarrow X$, the sequence*

$$j_!\mathbf{1} \longrightarrow \mathbf{1} \longrightarrow i_*\mathbf{1}$$

is a fiber sequence in $\mathsf{D}(X)$*;*

(iii) ***$\mathbb{A}^1$-homology trivial:*** *for $\pi\colon \mathbb{A}^1 \to \mathrm{Spec}(k)$, the unit map $\mathbf{1} \to \pi_!\pi^!\mathbf{1}$ is an equivalence.*

This category has an initial object, and that initial object is the motivic six-functor formalism SH *of Morel–Voevodsky.*

The proof of [DG22] is constructive, and recovers the construction of SH given in §2.1: enforcing the existence of left adjoints $f_\sharp$ to smooth pullbacks gives the stable presheaf category $\mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_{/X}; \mathsf{Sp})$; excision implies Nisnevich descent and forces passage to $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis}}(\mathsf{Sm}_{/X}; \mathsf{Sp})$; triviality of $\mathbb{A}^1$-homology forces $\mathbb{A}^1$-localization, yielding $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_{/X}; \mathsf{Sp})$; finally, $\otimes$-inverting the Tate object yields SH. We refer the reader to [Sch26, §11] for a clean exposition of the proof sketch.

***Remark* 2.2.24** (Realizations of motives)**.** The power of Theorem 2.2.23 lies in its corollary: any other six-functor formalism on C satisfying axioms (1)–(3) automatically receives a unique symmetric monoidal functor from SH, called its **realization**. Concrete examples include:

- ℓ-adic étale cohomology $\mathsf{D}_{\text{ét}}(-, \mathbb{Z}_\ell)$, when ℓ is invertible on the base;
- Betti realization $\mathsf{D}(-(\mathbb{C}), \mathbb{Z})$, for $\mathbb{C}$-schemes;
- de Rham realization in characteristic 0.

Each yields a symmetric monoidal functor from SH and identifies the corresponding cohomology theory as a representable spectrum (the ℓ-adic, Betti, or de Rham realization spectrum). This is the modern conceptual explanation for why "every" reasonable cohomology theory of varieties admits motives in the first place.

2.3. RELATING $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ AND $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$

We now take up the comparison between $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ and its naive stabilisation $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$ that was advertised in the chapter introduction. An object $E \in \mathsf{SH}(S)$ determines, and is determined by, its underlying graded-sheaf data $(E(j))_{j\in\mathbb{Z}}$ together with bonding equivalences $E(j) \simeq \underline{\mathrm{Map}}(\mathbb{T}_S, E(j+1))$. On the graded-sheaf side, the $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant cohomology theories coming from algebraic geometry — de Rham, Betti, étale, and so on — come equipped with additional structure: multiplicative products, first Chern classes, and the projective bundle formula. Our goal is to make the passage from such classical data to genuine motivic ring spectra precise.

The main result of the section is a symmetric monoidal equivalence

$$\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\mathrm{c,pbf}} \simeq \mathsf{Mod}_{\mathcal{P}'_S}(\mathsf{SH}(S))$$

due to Bachmann–Elmanto–Morrow (Proposition 2.3.6), identifying graded sheaves with Chern classes and pbf with modules over a certain commutative algebra $\mathcal{P}'_S \in \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{SH}(S))$. Composing with the forgetful functor then yields the **motivic Eilenberg–MacLane functor**

$$H\colon \mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\mathrm{c,pbf}} \longrightarrow \mathsf{SH}(S),$$

which sends classical $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant cohomology data to motivic ring spectra.

Our path to this equivalence is indirect. The tautological adjunction $\sigma^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}} \dashv \omega^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}$ between graded sheaves and motivic spectra fails to be monoidal at the $\mathbb{E}_2$ level: the switch map on $\mathbb{T}_S \wedge \mathbb{T}_S \in \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$ is not homotopic to the identity. Passing to Bott-periodic modules builds in precisely the symmetry one needs, and the equivalence falls out cleanly.

In this section, the same symbol $\otimes$ will arise in several closely-related monoidal categories: $\mathsf{SH}(S)$, $\mathsf{GrSH}(S)$, $\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$, and others obtained by free symmetric-monoidal constructions such as SSeq and $\mathsf{Sp}_T^{\mathrm{lax}}(-)$. To avoid a proliferation of decorated tensor symbols we follow the convention of Notation 2.3.13 and write $\otimes$ generically for the ambient monoidal product, relying on typing information (an object's category of residence) to disambiguate where necessary; $\wedge$ remains reserved for pure $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$-level expressions, such as the identity $\mathbb{T}_S \simeq S^1 \wedge \mathbb{G}_m$.

2.3.1. *Graded algebras and the projective bundle formula*

Construction 2.3.1. Equip $\mathbb{Z}^\delta$ with its discrete groupoid structure, so that $\mathsf{Fun}(\mathbb{Z}^\delta, C)$ acquires a symmetric monoidal structure via Day convolution with respect to the addition operation on $\mathbb{Z}$. Consider the square of commutative monoids in An:

$$\begin{tikzcd} \mathbb{F} \arrow[r] \arrow[d] & \mathbb{N} \arrow[d] \\ \mathbb{S} \arrow[r] & \mathbb{Z} \end{tikzcd}$$

where the vertical maps are group completions and the horizontal maps are induced by π_0. Restriction along $\mathbb{F} \to \mathbb{N} \to \mathbb{Z}$ yields a lax symmetric monoidal forgetful functor

$$\mathrm{res}\colon \mathsf{Gr}(C) = \mathsf{Fun}(\mathbb{Z}^\delta, C) \longrightarrow \mathsf{SSeq}(C).$$

Let $E^\star \in \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{Gr}(C))$ be a $\mathbb{Z}$-graded commutative algebra in C, and let $c\colon T \to E^1$ be a morphism in C (a **Bott element**). By the universal property of Sym, the element c extends uniquely to a morphism

$$\mathrm{Sym}(T_{\mathrm{sym}}) \longrightarrow \mathrm{res}(E)$$

of commutative algebras in $\mathsf{SSeq}(C)$, making $\mathrm{res}(E)$ canonically into a commutative algebra in $\mathsf{Sp}_T^{\mathrm{lax}}(C)$. Moreover, if the resulting bonding maps

$$E^n \otimes T \xrightarrow{1\otimes c} E^n \otimes E^1 \longrightarrow E^{n+1}$$

have adjoints that are equivalences, then (E, c) lifts to a commutative algebra in $\mathsf{Sp}_T(C)$ with $\omega^{\infty-n}(E, c) \simeq E^n$ for all $n \in \mathbb{Z}$.

The motivic case

We now specialize to $C = \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$ with $T = \Sigma^\infty \mathbb{T}_S$, where $\mathbb{T}_S := (\mathbb{P}^1_S, \infty) \in \mathsf{H}_*(S)$ is the Tate object we defined in § 2.1, and Σ^∞ denotes the suspension functor $\Sigma^\infty\colon \mathsf{H}_*(S) \to \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$; a Bott element is then a morphism $\Sigma^\infty \mathbb{T}_S \to E^1$.

Construction 2.3.2 (Q_S-modules and the projective bundle formula)**.** Let $\Sigma^\infty \mathbb{T}_S\langle 1\rangle \in \mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$ denote the graded sheaf concentrated in degree 1 with value $\Sigma^\infty \mathbb{T}_S$, and set

$$Q_S \;:=\; \mathrm{Sym}\big(\Sigma^\infty \mathbb{T}_S\langle 1\rangle\big) \;\in\; \mathsf{CAlg}\big(\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})\big).$$

One checks that $\sigma^\infty(Q_S) \simeq \mathrm{Sym}(\mathbb{T}_S\langle 1\rangle) \in \mathsf{Gr}(\mathsf{SH}(S))$, where on the right $\mathbb{T}_S$ stands for the image of $\Sigma^\infty \mathbb{T}_S$ under $\sigma^\infty\colon \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp}) \to \mathsf{SH}(S)$, consistent with the notation of §2.1.

We therefore consider the category of Q_S-modules, for which we introduce the abbreviation

$$\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_c \;:=\; \mathsf{Mod}_{Q_S}\big(\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})\big).$$

Given $E \in \mathsf{CAlg}\big(\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\mathrm{c}}\big)$, the bonding maps of Construction 2.3.1 take the form

$$b^n : E^n \otimes \Sigma^\infty \mathbb{T}_S \longrightarrow E^{n+1}, \qquad n \in \mathbb{Z}.$$

Passing to adjoints, these become

$$b^{n,\dagger} : E^n \longrightarrow \Omega_{\Sigma^\infty \mathbb{T}_S} E^{n+1} \;\simeq\; \mathrm{fib}\big(E^{n+1}(\mathbb{P}^1_-) \xrightarrow{\infty^*} E^{n+1}\big),$$

where ∞^* denotes restriction along the inclusion of the point at infinity. The requirement that every $b^{n,\dagger}$ is an equivalence is precisely the $\mathbb{P}^1$ **bundle formula** (pbf).

We write

$$\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\mathrm{c,pbf}}$$

for the full subcategory of Q_S-modules satisfying the $\mathbb{P}^1$ bundle formula.

The passage from such data to a genuine motivic spectrum is encoded in the functor H announced at the start of the section; we construct it in §2.3.4, after the Bott-periodic groundwork of §2.3.3 is in place.

2.3.2. *The $\sigma^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}} \dashv \omega^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}$ adjunction and periodization*

To construct the Eilenberg–MacLane functor H, we approach the problem from the reverse direction: from a motivic spectrum $E \in \mathsf{SH}(S)$, extract a graded sheaf and ask when this graded sheaf lies in $\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\mathrm{c,pbf}}$.

By Corollary 2.1.13, for each $j \in \mathbb{Z}$, we can extract an $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant Nisnevich sheaf from E via the formula

$$E(j) = \mathrm{map}_{\mathsf{SH}(S)}(M_S(-), E \otimes \mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes j}).$$

***Warning* 2.3.3.** Our notation is different from [BEM25, p. 3.2], where they use the "$\mathbb{G}_m$-twist" and then define $E(j)$ as $\mathrm{map}_{\mathsf{SH}(S)}(M_S(-), E \otimes \mathbb{G}_m^{\otimes j})$. Our notation is close to the T-spectra we construct in § 2.1.3, and we believe that it is more natural.

Thus, we obtain

$$\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp}) \underset{\omega^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}}{\overset{\sigma^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}}{\underset{\longleftarrow}{\overset{\longrightarrow}{\perp}}}} \mathsf{SH}(S).$$

where

$$\sigma^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}(E^\star) = \bigoplus_{j \in \mathbb{Z}} \sigma^\infty(E^j) \otimes \mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes j}.$$

and thus

$$\omega^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}(E)^j \simeq E(j) \simeq \omega^\infty(E \otimes \mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes j}).$$

Unfortunately, the functor $\omega^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}$ does not commute with pullback functors, and $\omega^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}$ is also not very multiplicative. Since $\mathsf{Gr}(\mathcal{C}) \simeq \mathsf{PShv}(\mathbb{Z}^\delta) \otimes \mathcal{C}$, the $\mathbb{E}_n$-monoidal structures on $\sigma^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}$ are the same as $\mathbb{E}_n$-monoidal maps $\mathbb{Z} \to \mathcal{P}ic(\mathsf{SH}(S))$ sending 1 to $\mathbb{T}_S$. When $n = 1$, since $\mathbb{Z}$ is a free monoid on an invertible generator, there is such a canonical monoidal map and hence an induced monoidal structure on $\sigma^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}$. Thus, its right adjoint $\omega^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}$ inherits the desired natural lax monoidal structure, yielding

$$\mathsf{Alg}(\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})) \leftarrow \mathsf{Alg}(\mathsf{SH}(S)).$$

But when $n = 2$, the existence of an $\mathbb{E}_2$-monoidal structure on $\sigma^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}$ requires the switch map on $\mathbb{T}_S \otimes \mathbb{T}_S$ to be homotopic to the identity, which is not always true.

So, we need to consider another way.

Definition 2.3.4. For a commutative algebra $E \in \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{SH}(S))$, a **periodization** of E is the data of a compatible commutative algebra structure on $E \otimes \mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes\star} \in \mathsf{GrSH}(S)$. Let $\mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{SH}(S))_{\mathrm{per}}$ denote the category of commutative algebras in $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ equipped with a chosen periodization, with morphisms required to respect the periodization.

Now, we can find that $\omega^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}$ upgrades to a functor (due to symmetric monoidality of ω^∞)

$$\mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})) \leftarrow \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{SH}(S))_{\mathrm{per}}.$$

But we still do not know whether $\mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{SH}(S))_{\mathrm{per}}$ admits an interpretation intrinsic to $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ (here, $\mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{SH}(S))_{\mathrm{per}}$ is defined in terms of $\mathsf{GrSH}(S)$). We want to reinterpret periodized motivic ring spectra as commutative algebras over a certain commutative ring in $\mathsf{SH}(S)$.

For this, we need the notion of Bott-periodic modules.

2.3.3. *Bott-periodic modules and the BEM equivalence*

Definition 2.3.5 (Bott-periodic modules)**.** Let $E \in \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathcal{C})$ and let $\beta\colon T \to E$ be a morphism in $\mathcal{C}$ (the **Bott element**). The category of **β-periodic E-modules** is the monoidal Bousfield localization

$$P_\beta \mathsf{Mod}_E(\mathcal{C}) \subset \mathsf{Mod}_E(\mathcal{C})$$

obtained by inverting the map $\beta\colon T \otimes E \to E$.

Just like Construction 2.3.2, consider $\mathcal{P}_S := \mathrm{Sym}(\mathbb{T}_S\langle 1\rangle) \in \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{GrSH}(S))$. Write $\beta\colon \mathcal{P}_S \otimes \mathbb{T}_S\langle 1\rangle \to \mathcal{P}_S$, then we consider $P_\beta \mathcal{P}_S$. By [BH21, Lemma 12.1], $P_\beta\mathcal{P}_S$ is given by the telescope construction

$$\operatorname{colim}\left(\mathcal{P}_S \xrightarrow{\beta} \mathcal{P}_S \otimes \mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes -1}\langle -1\rangle \xrightarrow{\beta} \mathcal{P}_S \otimes \mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes -2}\langle -2\rangle \xrightarrow{\beta} \cdots\right).$$

Now, we take $\mathcal{P}'_S := (P_\beta\mathcal{P}_S)^0$ to be the degree 0 piece. Note that in $\mathsf{GrSH}(S)$, we have an equivalence $E \otimes \mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes\star} \simeq E \otimes_{\mathcal{P}'_S} \mathrm{L}_\beta \mathcal{P}_S$.

Given a map $\mathcal{P}'_S \to E$ in $\mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{SH}(S))$, then $E \otimes_{\mathcal{P}'_S} \mathrm{L}_\beta\mathcal{P}_S$ defines the periodization of E. Conversely, given a periodization on some $E \in \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{SH}(S))$, the unit map of E induces $\mathbb{T}_S \to E \otimes \mathbb{T}_S$, which then induces a map of commutative algebras $\mathcal{P}_S \to E \otimes \mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes\star}$, which then factors $\mathrm{L}_\beta\mathcal{P}_S \to E \otimes \mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes\star}$, finally, passing to degree zero pieces defines the desired map $\mathcal{P}'_S \to E$.

Thus, we obtain an equivalence

$$\mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{SH}(S))_{\mathrm{per}} \simeq \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{SH}(S))_{\mathcal{P}'_S/}.$$

So, the right domain is $\mathsf{Mod}_{\mathcal{P}'_S}(\mathsf{SH}(S))$.

Proposition 2.3.6 ([BEM25, Proposition 3.15])**.** *There is a monoidal equivalence $\omega_\otimes^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}$ filling the following commutative square of monoidal categories and lax monoidal functors:*

$$\begin{tikzcd}
\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\mathrm{c,pbf}} \arrow[d] & \mathsf{Mod}_{\mathcal{P}'_S}(\mathsf{SH}(S)) \arrow[l, "\omega_\otimes^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}"'] \arrow[d] \\
\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp}) & \mathsf{SH}(S). \arrow[l, "\omega^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}"]
\end{tikzcd}$$

Moreover, $\omega_\otimes^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}$ upgrades to a symmetric monoidal equivalence. Consequently, the motivic Eilenberg–MacLane functor H is the inverse of $\omega_\otimes^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}$.

Proof. In fact, $\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\mathrm{c,pbf}}$ can be written as

$$P_v \mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\mathrm{c}}$$

for $v\colon \mathcal{Q}_S \otimes \Sigma^\infty \mathbb{P}^1_S\langle 1\rangle \to \mathcal{Q}_S$. Since $\mathcal{Q}_S$ is the unit of $\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\mathrm{c}}$, one can apply [Hoy20, Proposition 3.2] and then obtain

$$P_v \mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\mathrm{c}} \simeq P_v \mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\mathrm{c}}[(\mathcal{Q}_S \otimes \Sigma^\infty \mathbb{P}^1_S\langle 1\rangle)^{-1}],$$

where the right hand side is the formal inversion of $\mathcal{Q}_S \otimes \Sigma^\infty \mathbb{P}^1_S\langle 1\rangle$ via Proposition 2.1.3. Since we have $\sigma^\infty(\mathcal{Q}_S) = \mathcal{P}_S$, we have

$$\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\mathrm{c,pbf}} \simeq P_\beta \mathsf{Mod}_{\mathcal{P}_S}(\mathsf{GrSH}(S)) \simeq \mathsf{Mod}_{P_\beta \mathcal{P}_S}(\mathsf{GrSH}(S))$$

the second equivalence comes from [BH21, Lemma 12.1]. Thus, everything reduces to showing that

$$\mathsf{Mod}_{P_\beta \mathcal{P}_S}(\mathsf{GrSH}(S)) \simeq \mathsf{Mod}_{\mathcal{P}'_S}(\mathsf{SH}(S)),$$

but it follows from the discussion above. □

2.3.4. *The motivic Eilenberg–MacLane functor H*

With Proposition 2.3.6 in hand, we can finally define H as the inverse of the equivalence $\omega_\otimes^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}$.

Definition 2.3.7. The procedure above defines the **motivic Eilenberg–MacLane functor**

$$H\colon \mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\mathrm{c,pbf}} \to \mathsf{SH}(S).$$

"Traditional cohomology theories" of algebraic geometry which are $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant (e.g. algebraic de Rham cohomology, Betti cohomology) give rise to objects of $\mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\mathrm{c,pbf}})$. Indeed, such cohomology theories have the following structure:

- they are a family of $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant Nisnevich $\mathsf{D}(\mathbb{Z})$-valued sheaves $F(j)$, equipped with compatible multiplication maps $F(i) \otimes F(j) \to F(i+j)$;
- they admit a theory of Chern classes map $c_1\colon \Gamma_{\mathrm{Nis}}(-, \mathbb{G}_m)[1] \to F(1)$;
- they satisfy the projective bundle formula: for every smooth scheme $X \in \mathsf{Sm}_S$ and $j \in \mathbb{Z}$ and $n \geq 1$, there exists an equivalence

$$\sum_{i=0}^{n} c_1(\mathcal{O}(1))^i\colon \bigoplus_{i=0}^{n} F(j-i)(X) \xrightarrow{\sim} F(j)(\mathbb{P}^n_X),$$

  when $n = 1$, it recovers the $\mathbb{P}^1$-bundle formula above.

From a modern point of view the multiplication maps assemble to form a commutative algebra structure in $\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{D}(\mathbb{Z}))$ and then forgetting $\mathbb{Z}$-linear structure we obtain $F(\star) \in \mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{D}(\mathbb{Z}))$. Meanwhile, by restricting attention to the line bundle $\mathcal{O}(1) \in \mathrm{Pic}(\mathbb{P}^1_S)$, the first Chern class map induces a morphism $\Sigma^\infty \mathbb{P}^1_S \to F(1)$, as the composition

$$\Sigma^\infty \mathbb{P}^1_S \xrightarrow{[\mathcal{O}(1)]} \mathcal{P}ic \simeq \tau^{\leq 1}\Gamma_{\mathrm{Zar}}(-, \mathbb{G}_m)[1] \to F(1),$$

we thus indeed obtain an object of $\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\mathrm{c,pbf}}$ and then corresponds to a motivic spectrum F.

2.3.5. *Promoting Bott-periodic algebras to T-spectra*

As a final application of the Bott-periodic framework, we record a general mechanism for promoting a Bott-periodic commutative algebra to a T-spectrum. This will be the key tool in the construction of motivic K-theory below.

Proposition 2.3.8 (Promotion to T-spectra). *Let $E \in \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathcal{C})$ and $\beta\colon T \to E$ be a Bott element. Then the suspension functor induces an equivalence*

$$P_\beta \mathsf{Mod}_E(\mathcal{C}) \;\simeq\; P_\beta \mathsf{Mod}_{\sigma^\infty(E)}\big(\mathsf{Sp}_T(\mathcal{C})\big).$$

Consequently, E admits an essentially unique promotion to a commutative algebra

$$\underline{E} \;\in\; \mathsf{CAlg}\big(\mathsf{Sp}_T(\mathcal{C})\big) \qquad \text{with } \omega^{\infty-n}\underline{E} \simeq E \text{ for all } n \in \mathbb{Z}.$$

2.3.6. *Example: the motivic K-theory spectrum* KGL

We now apply the Bott-periodic construction (Proposition 2.3.8) to build the motivic K-theory spectrum $\mathrm{KGL}_S \in \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{SH}(S))$.

Let $\mathrm{K}\colon \mathsf{Sch}^{\mathrm{qcqs,op}} \to \mathsf{Sp}$ denote non-connective algebraic K-theory. Define homotopy K-theory

$$\mathrm{KH}(X) \;:=\; \mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}\mathrm{K}(X) \;=\; \mathrm{colim}_{[n]\in\mathbf{\Delta}^{\mathrm{op}}}\, \mathrm{K}\big(X \times \Delta^n\big).$$

Restricted to Sm_S, KH defines an object of $\mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp}))$.

The Bott element is the class

$$\beta \;=\; [\mathcal{O}(-1)] - [\mathcal{O}] \;\in\; \mathrm{fib}\big(\mathrm{K}(\mathbb{P}^1) \to \mathrm{K}(\infty)\big).$$

Using $\mathbb{T}_S \simeq \mathbb{P}^1_S/\{\infty\}$ this gives a morphism $\beta\colon \mathbb{T}_S \to \mathrm{KH}$ in $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$.

Definition 2.3.9 (KGL). The pair (KH, β) is Bott-periodic, and Proposition 2.3.8 promotes it to a commutative algebra

$$\mathrm{KGL}_S \;\in\; \mathsf{CAlg}\big(\mathsf{SH}(S)\big)$$

with $\omega_{\mathbb{T}}^{\infty-n}\mathrm{KGL}_S \simeq \mathrm{KH}$ for all $n \in \mathbb{Z}$, reflecting the Bott periodicity $\sigma\mathrm{KGL}_S \simeq \mathrm{KGL}_S$.

Proposition 2.3.10 (Base change for KGL). *For any morphism of schemes $f : Y \to X$, the natural map*

$$f^*\mathrm{KGL}_X \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathrm{KGL}_Y$$

is an equivalence in $\mathsf{SH}(Y)$.

To show this, we need following proposition.

Proposition 2.3.11 (Bhatt–Lurie [Elm+20, Appendix A]). *The connective K-theory functor*

$$\mathrm{K}_{\geq 0}\colon \mathrm{CRing}_R \longrightarrow \mathsf{Sp}$$

is left Kan extended from its restriction to the subcategory SmRing_R of smooth R-algebras.

Proof of Proposition 2.3.11. It suffices to show that the rank-n vector bundle stack $\mathsf{Vect}_n : \mathrm{CRing}_R \to \mathsf{An}$ is left Kan extended from SmRing_R. A presheaf is left Kan extended from a subcategory iff it is a colimit of representables from that subcategory. Consider the chain of morphisms of stacks

$$\coprod_k U_{n,k} \longrightarrow \coprod_k \mathsf{Gr}_n(\mathbb{A}^k) \longrightarrow \mathsf{Vect}_n,$$

where Gr_n encodes affine bundles, while $U_{n,k}$ encodes smooth affine bundles. On affine schemes, the first map is surjective: every vector bundle can be embedded into trivial vector bundle. So this map is an effective epimorphism, and we may write Vect_n as the colimit of the Čech-nerve of this composite. But this Cech-nerve consists of disjoint unions of smooth affines, which are representables.. □

Proof of Proposition 2.3.10. By Proposition 2.3.11, $\mathrm{K}_{\geq 0}$ is left Kan extended from smooth affine algebras; the same holds for KH after $\mathbb{A}^1$-localization. Left Kan extension is automatically compatible with base change, so $f^*\mathrm{KH}_X \simeq \mathrm{KH}_Y$. Since the Bott element is also natural, the Bott-periodic construction (Proposition 2.3.8) gives $f^*\mathrm{KGL}_X \simeq \mathrm{KGL}_Y$. □

Corollary 2.3.12 (Cisinski)**.** *The presheaf* KH *is a cdh sheaf on* $\mathsf{Sch}^{\mathrm{qcqs}}$.

Proof. By Corollary 2.2.22, SH is a cdh sheaf on $\mathsf{Sch}^{\mathrm{qcqs}}$. Combined with Proposition 2.3.10, this means that the assignment $X \mapsto \mathrm{KGL}_X \in \mathsf{SH}(X)$ is itself a cdh-local section of the cocartesian fibration $\int \mathsf{SH}$. Taking mapping anima out of the unit yields

$$\mathrm{KH}(X) \simeq \mathrm{Map}_{\mathsf{SH}(X)}(\mathbf{1}, \mathrm{KGL}_X),$$

which inherits cdh descent. □

2.3.7. *The homotopy t-structure*

We end this section with the homotopy t-structure on $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ and compare it, via the $\sigma^\infty \dashv \omega^\infty$ adjunction, with the Postnikov t-structure on $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$. We follow [BH21, Appendix B].

Notation 2.3.13 (Conventions on bigradings)**.** Recall from §1.4.2 that $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ carries two canonical gradings:

- the **simplicial grading**, given by the categorical suspension $[-]$ inherited from the stability of $\mathsf{SH}(S)$;
- the **Tate grading**, given by tensoring with $\mathbb{G}_m$.

Two conventions for labelling the resulting bigraded spheres are in common use. In the **Morel convention**, $S^{p,q} \in \mathsf{SH}(S)$ denotes the sphere of total degree p and weight q:

$$S^{p,q} \simeq (S^1)^{\otimes(p-q)} \otimes \mathbb{G}_m^{\otimes q}.$$

In the **Bachmann–Hoyois convention** [BH21], one labels the same sphere by the pair (a, b) of simplicial and Tate degrees, so that

$$S^{a,b}_{\mathrm{BH}} \simeq (S^1)^{\otimes a} \otimes \mathbb{G}_m^{\otimes b}.$$

The translation between the two conventions is

$$(p, q) = (a + b, b), \qquad (a, b) = (p - q, q).$$

Throughout this section we work with the (a, b) convention. Unless stated otherwise, $\otimes$ denotes the monoidal product of $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ and $\wedge$ the monoidal product of $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$ and $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$.

Notation 2.3.14. Let $I \subset \mathbb{Z} \times \mathbb{Z}$ be a subset, where $(i, j) \in I$ represents the bidegree $(a, b) =$ (simplicial, Tate). We denote by $\mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq I}$ the full subcategory of $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ generated under colimits and extensions by

$$\{\, S^{i+j,j} \otimes M_S(X) \mid X \in \mathsf{Sm}_S,\ (i, j) \in I \,\}.$$

Example 2.3.15. When $I = \varnothing$, we have $\mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq \varnothing} = \{0\}$.

Since $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ is presentable stable and the generating family above is small, [Lur17, Proposition 1.4.4.11] implies that $\mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq I}$ is the connective part of an accessible t-structure on $\mathsf{SH}(S)$. We denote the corresponding coconnective part by $\mathsf{SH}(S)_{<I}$, consisting of all $E \in \mathsf{SH}(S)$ such that $\mathrm{Map}(F, E) \simeq *$ for every $F \in \mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq I}$. We denote by $\tau_{\geq I}$ the right adjoint to $\mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq I} \hookrightarrow \mathsf{SH}(S)$ and $\tau_{<I}$ the left adjoint to $\mathsf{SH}(S)_{<I} \hookrightarrow \mathsf{SH}(S)$.

Different choices of I produce different t-structures adapted to different purposes. Among them, one is distinguished by its role in Morel's work [Mor05] on the stable $\mathbb{A}^1$-connectivity theorems.

Definition 2.3.16 (Homotopy t-structure)**.** The **homotopy t-structure** on $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ is the t-structure determined by $I = \{0\} \times \mathbb{Z}$. We write $\mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq 0} := \mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq \{0\}\times\mathbb{Z}}$, and more generally $\mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq d} := \mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq \{d\}\times\mathbb{Z}}$ for $d \in \mathbb{Z}$. We denote by $\tau_{\geq d}$ the right adjoint to $\mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq d} \hookrightarrow \mathsf{SH}(S)$ and by $\tau_{<d}$ the left adjoint to $\mathsf{SH}(S)_{<d} \hookrightarrow \mathsf{SH}(S)$.

Unpacking the notation, $\mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq d}$ is the full subcategory generated under colimits and extensions by the objects $\Sigma^{d+j,j} M_S(X)$ with $X \in \mathsf{Sm}_S$ and $j \in \mathbb{Z}$.

Next, we record some functoriality properties of $\mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq I}$. For every morphism $f : S' \to S$, the functor $f^* \colon \mathsf{SH}(S) \to \mathsf{SH}(S')$ sends the generators $\Sigma^{i+j,j} M_S(X)$ to $\Sigma^{i+j,j} M_{S'}(X \times_S S')$, which are again generators; hence f^* is right t-exact, and consequently its right adjoint f_* is left t-exact. The following lemmas improve on these observations.

Lemma 2.3.17 ([BH21, B.1])**.** *If $f : S' \to S$ is a pro-smooth morphism, then $f^* \colon \mathsf{SH}(S) \to \mathsf{SH}(S')$ is t-exact.*

Proof. Right t-exactness was noted above, so we must show that f^* preserves the coconnective part $\mathsf{SH}(S)_{<I}$.

We first treat the smooth case. If f is smooth, then f^* admits a left adjoint $f_\# \colon \mathsf{SH}(S') \to \mathsf{SH}(S)$ sending $\Sigma^{i+j,j} M_{S'}(X') \mapsto \Sigma^{i+j,j} M_S(X')$ (where X' is regarded as smooth over S via f). Thus $f_\#$ is right t-exact, and consequently f^* is left t-exact. Combined with right t-exactness, f^* is t-exact in the smooth case.

Now suppose $f : S' \to S$ is pro-smooth, with $S' = \lim_{\alpha \in A} S_\alpha$ a cofiltered limit of smooth S-schemes $f_\alpha \colon S_\alpha \to S$ with affine transition maps. Let $E \in \mathsf{SH}(S)_{<I}$; we show $f^*E \in \mathsf{SH}(S')_{<I}$, equivalently $\mathrm{Map}(F, f^*E) \simeq *$ for every $F = \Sigma^{i+j,j} M_{S'}(X')$ with $X' \in \mathsf{Sm}_{S'}$ and $(i,j) \in I$.

By [Gro67, 8.8.2 and 17.7.8], there exists an index $\alpha_0 \in A$ and a smooth S_{α_0}-scheme X_{α_0} with $X' \simeq S' \times_{S_{\alpha_0}} X_{\alpha_0}$. By continuity of $\mathsf{SH}(-)$ [CD19, Proposition 4.3.4],

$$\mathrm{Map}_{\mathsf{SH}(S')}\big(\Sigma^{i+j,j} M_{S'}(X'),\ f^*E\big) \ \simeq\ \operatorname*{colim}_{\alpha \geq \alpha_0} \mathrm{Map}_{\mathsf{SH}(S_\alpha)}\big(\Sigma^{i+j,j} M_{S_\alpha}(X_\alpha),\ f_\alpha^* E\big),$$

where $X_\alpha := S_\alpha \times_{S_{\alpha_0}} X_{\alpha_0}$. Since each f_α is smooth, the already established smooth case gives $f_\alpha^* E \in \mathsf{SH}(S_\alpha)_{<I}$, so every term in the colimit is contractible. □

Lemma 2.3.18 ([BH21, B.2])**.** *If $\iota \colon Z \to S$ is a closed immersion, then $\iota_* \colon \mathsf{SH}(Z) \to \mathsf{SH}(S)$ is t-exact.*

Proof. Left t-exactness follows from the general fact noted above. For right t-exactness, since ι_* preserves colimits, the full subcategory $\{E \in \mathsf{SH}(Z) \mid \iota_* E \in \mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq I}\}$ is closed under colimits and extensions. It therefore suffices to show $\iota_*(\Sigma^{a+j,j} M_Z(Y)) \in \mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq I}$ for all $Y \in \mathsf{Sm}_Z$ and $(a,j) \in I$. By [Gro67, p. 18.1.1], locally on Y we can write $Y \simeq X \times_S Z$ for some $X \in \mathsf{Sm}_S$, so it suffices to show that $\iota_* \iota^*$ preserves $\mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq I}$.

Consider the localization exact sequence

$$j_! j^* E \longrightarrow E \longrightarrow \iota_* \iota^* E,$$

where $j\colon U \hookrightarrow S$ is the open complement of Z. Since j is an open immersion, $j_! \simeq j_\#$ is right t-exact (as in the smooth case of Lemma 2.3.17), and j^* is right t-exact generally, so $j_! j^*$ is right t-exact. If $E \in \mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq I}$, then $j_! j^* E \in \mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq I}$, and so by the exact sequence $\iota_* \iota^* E \in \mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq I}$. □

By the lemmas above, one can derive the following property, which says that motivic spectra are detected by their pullbacks to points.

Proposition 2.3.19 ([BH21, B.3]). *Let S be a qcqs scheme locally of finite Krull dimension and let $E \in \mathsf{SH}(S)$. Then $E \in \mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq I}$ if and only if $s^* E \in \mathsf{SH}(\kappa(s))_{\geq I}$ for every point $s \in S$, where $s\colon \operatorname{Spec} \kappa(s) \to S$ is the canonical map.*

Proof. Necessity is clear: $s^*\colon \mathsf{SH}(S) \to \mathsf{SH}(\kappa(s))$ is right t-exact.

For sufficiency, we proceed by induction on $d := \dim S$. Assume $s^* E \in \mathsf{SH}(\kappa(s))_{\geq I}$ for every $s \in S$; we show $\tau_{<I} E \simeq *$.

By Proposition 1.1.5 and Theorem 2.2.7, $\tau_{<I} E \simeq *$ can be checked on the henselizations $S_s^h := \operatorname{Spec} \mathcal{O}_{S,s}^h$ for $s \in S$. Since $S_s^h \to S$ is pro-smooth, Lemma 2.3.17 gives $(\tau_{<I} E)|_{S_s^h} \simeq \tau_{<I}(E|_{S_s^h})$, so we may replace S by S_s^h and assume S is local Henselian with closed point $\iota\colon \operatorname{Spec} \kappa(s) \hookrightarrow S$ and open complement $j\colon U \hookrightarrow S$, where $\dim U < \dim S$.

Consider the localization cofiber sequence

$$j_! j^* E \longrightarrow E \longrightarrow \iota_* \iota^* E.$$

For any $u \in U$, $(j^* E)_u \simeq E_{j(u)} \in \mathsf{SH}(\kappa(u))_{\geq I}$ by assumption, so by the induction hypothesis $j^* E \in \mathsf{SH}(U)_{\geq I}$, and hence $j_! j^* E \in \mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq I}$ (since j is an open immersion, $j_! \simeq j_\#$ is right t-exact, as in the proof of Lemma 2.3.18). Also, $\iota^* E = s^* E \in \mathsf{SH}(\kappa(s))_{\geq I}$ by assumption, and Lemma 2.3.18 gives $\iota_* \iota^* E \in \mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq I}$. Both outer terms of the cofiber sequence lie in $\mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq I}$, hence so does E. □

Postnikov t-structure and Homotopy t-structure

Recall the adjunction

$$\sigma^\infty\colon \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp}) \rightleftarrows \mathsf{SH}(S)\colon \omega^\infty$$

introduced in §2.1.4. To match the homotopy t-structure on $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ with something on the unstable side, we equip $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$ with the following natural t-structure.

Definition 2.3.20 (Postnikov t-structure). The **Postnikov t-structure** on $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$ has connective part

$$\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\geq 0} := \left\{ F \,\middle|\, \pi_i(F) = 0 \text{ as Nisnevich sheaves for all } i < 0 \right\},$$

where $\pi_i(F)$ denotes the Nisnevich sheafification of the presheaf $X \mapsto \pi_i F(X)$.

***Remark* 2.3.21.** It is not automatic from the definition that the connective subcategory above is the non-negative part of an accessible t-structure on $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$: one needs to verify that it is presentable and closed under colimits and extensions, and that the corresponding truncation functors exist. This requires Morel's stable $\mathbb{A}^1$-connectivity theorem (Theorem 2.3.28 below) to control how $\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}$ interacts with Nisnevich connectivity.

The Postnikov t-structure is the one we care about because it pairs well with σ^∞:

Proposition 2.3.22. *The functor $\sigma^\infty\colon \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp}) \to \mathsf{SH}(S)$ is right t-exact from the Postnikov t-structure to the homotopy t-structure.*

Proof. Let $F \in \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\geq 0}$. We must show $\sigma^\infty F \in \mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq 0}$, equivalently $\mathrm{Map}_{\mathsf{SH}(S)}(\sigma^\infty F, E) \simeq *$ for every $E \in \mathsf{SH}(S)_{<0}$. By adjunction this is $\mathrm{Map}(F, \omega^\infty E) \simeq *$.

It therefore suffices to show that $\omega^\infty E$ lies in $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{<0}$, i.e. has $\pi_i = 0$ as a Nisnevich sheaf for $i \geq 0$. By definition of $\mathsf{SH}(S)_{<0}$ (the right orthogonal of $\mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq\{0\}\times\mathbb{Z}}$), we have

$$\mathrm{Map}_{\mathsf{SH}(S)}\big(\Sigma^{j,j} M_S(X),\, E\big) \simeq * \quad \text{for all } X \in \mathsf{Sm}_S,\ j \in \mathbb{Z}.$$

Taking $j = 0$, we get $\mathrm{Map}(M_S(X), E) \simeq *$, i.e. $\pi_i \omega^\infty E(X) = 0$ for all $i \geq 0$ and $X \in \mathsf{Sm}_S$. The presheaves $\pi_i \omega^\infty E$ thus vanish for $i \geq 0$, and so do their Nisnevich sheafifications. □

The homotopy t-structure on $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ also admits a description directly in terms of the bigraded homotopy sheaves of E.

Definition 2.3.23 (Bigraded homotopy sheaves)**.** For $E \in \mathsf{SH}(S)$ and integers $i, j \in \mathbb{Z}$, the (i, j)**-th homotopy sheaf** of E is the Nisnevich sheaf $\pi_{i,j}(E)$ associated with the presheaf

$$X \longmapsto \pi_0 \mathrm{Map}_{\mathsf{SH}(S)}\big(\Sigma^{i,j} M_S(X),\, E\big).$$

By [Mor03, Proposition 5.1.14], the family $\{\pi_{i,j}\}_{i,j\in\mathbb{Z}}$ is jointly conservative on $\mathsf{SH}(S)$: a morphism in $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ is an equivalence if and only if it induces isomorphisms on all bigraded homotopy sheaves.

To relate the bigraded picture to the Postnikov one, we use the T-spectrum structure on $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ with $T = \mathbb{T}_S = \Sigma^\infty \mathbb{P}^1_S$. Recall from Corollary 2.1.13 that a motivic spectrum E has a family of "levels"

$$E(j) \;\coloneqq\; \omega^{\infty - j} E \;\simeq\; \omega^\infty\big(E \otimes \mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes j}\big) \;\in\; \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp}),$$

one for each $j \in \mathbb{Z}$.

Definition 2.3.24 (Tate-graded homotopy sheaves)**.** For $E \in \mathsf{SH}(S)$ and $i, j \in \mathbb{Z}$, set

$$\pi_i(E)_j \;\coloneqq\; \pi_i\, E(j) \;=\; \pi_i\, \omega^\infty\big(E \otimes \mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes j}\big),$$

the i-th (classical) Nisnevich homotopy sheaf of the j-th level $E(j)$ of E.

***Remark* 2.3.25.** Unwinding the definition,

$$\pi_i(E)_j \;=\; \pi_{i-2j,\,-j}(E),$$

since $\mathbb{T}_S = S^1 \wedge \mathbb{G}_m \simeq S^{2,1}$. Some authors (e.g. [BEM25, §3.2]) instead use the "$\mathbb{G}_m$-twist" and define $E(j) = \omega^\infty(E \otimes \mathbb{G}_m^{\otimes j})$, in which case the analogous formula becomes $\pi_i(E)_j = \pi_{i-j,\,-j}(E)$. Our choice aligns with the general T-spectrum formalism of §2.1.3, where $\mathbb{T}_S$ is the invertible object. Under both conventions, however, the combination $i - j$ coincides with the Morel weight $p - q$ of $\pi_{p,q}(E)$, because

$$p - q \;=\; (i - 2j) - (-j) \;=\; i - j \qquad \text{(our convention)},$$

and similarly $p - q = (i - j) - (-j) = i$ collapses to $i - j$ after the appropriate relabelling in the $\mathbb{G}_m$-twist convention.

The conservativity of $\{\pi_{i,j}\}$ on $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ (Proposition above) translates, via the substitution $(i,j) \leftrightarrow (p,q) = (i-2j, -j)$, into the conservativity of $\{\pi_i(E)_j\}_{i,j}$: a morphism in $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ is an equivalence iff it induces isomorphisms on $\pi_i(-)_j$ for all i, j. This is the precise sense in which the Postnikov t-structure on each Tate level $E(j)$ controls E.

The two t-structures — the homotopy t-structure on $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ and the Postnikov t-structure on each level — agree, in a precise sense, as soon as the base S satisfies Morel's $\mathbb{A}^1$-connectivity property.

Morel originally isolated a fundamental property of the base scheme S which governs the interaction between $\mathbb{A}^1$-localization and Nisnevich connectivity.

Definition 2.3.26 ($\mathbb{A}^1$-connectivity property, [Mor05, Definition 1]). A scheme S is said to satisfy the **$\mathbb{A}^1$-connectivity property** if the $\mathbb{A}^1$-localization functor

$$\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1} : \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis}}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp}) \longrightarrow \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$$

is t-exact for the Postnikov t-structures on both sides; equivalently, if $\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}$ preserves 0-connective objects.

Theorem 2.3.27 (Stable $\mathbb{A}^1$-connectivity, [Mor05, Theorem 6.1.8]). *Every field k satisfies the $\mathbb{A}^1$-connectivity property. That is, for $S = \operatorname{Spec} k$ and every $F \in \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis}}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\geq n}$, one has $\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1} F \in \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\geq n}$.*

Morel conjectured that the $\mathbb{A}^1$-connectivity property holds more generally; it is known to fail for some schemes, but the following *shifted* version recovers a uniform statement for all qcqs schemes of finite valuative dimension.

Theorem 2.3.28 (Shifted stable $\mathbb{A}^1$-connectivity, [BK25]). *Let S be a qcqs scheme with $d := \mathrm{v.dim}(S) < \infty$. For every integer n and every $F \in \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis}}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\geq n}$, the $\mathbb{A}^1$-localization satisfies*

$$\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1} F \in \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\geq n-d}.$$

In particular, $\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}$ loses at most d degrees of connectivity, and recovers Theorem 2.3.27 when $d = 0$.

It follows from a theorem of Hoyois that, when S satisfies the $\mathbb{A}^1$-connectivity property, the homotopy t-structure on $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ is detected by the Tate-graded homotopy sheaves:

Proposition 2.3.29 ([Hoy15, Theorem 2.3]). *Let S be a scheme satisfying the $\mathbb{A}^1$-connectivity property, and let $E \in \mathsf{SH}(S)$. Then:*

(i) $E \in \mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq d}$ if and only if $\pi_i(E)_j = 0$ for all $i - j < d$.

(ii) $E \in \mathsf{SH}(S)_{\leq d}$ if and only if $\pi_i(E)_j = 0$ for all $i - j > d$.

Equivalently, substituting $(p,q) = (i-2j, -j)$: $E \in \mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq d}$ iff $\pi_{p,q}(E) = 0$ for all $p - q < d$, and similarly for the coconnective part.

Combining Proposition 2.3.22 with Theorem 2.3.28, one sees that the composite

$$\sigma^\infty \circ \mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1} : \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis}}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp}) \longrightarrow \mathsf{SH}(S)$$

sends the n-connective part of the Postnikov t-structure into the $(n-d)$-connective part of the homotopy t-structure, and is t-exact over a base satisfying the $\mathbb{A}^1$-connectivity property.

2.4. Slice filtration and Orientation

We next discuss Voevodsky's slice filtration on $\mathsf{SH}(S)$.

2.4.1. *Recollection of filtrations*

Definition 2.4.1. Let C be a category. The category of **(decreasing) filtrations** $\mathsf{Fil}(C)$ is defined to be

$$\mathsf{Fil}(C) := \mathsf{Fun}(\mathbb{Z}^{\mathrm{op}}, C).$$

The category of **increasing filtrations** is defined similarly, with $\mathbb{Z}^{\mathrm{op}}$ replaced by $\mathbb{Z}$.

Intuitively, a filtration $F^\star$ looks like a sequence

$$\cdots \longrightarrow F^{s+1} \longrightarrow F^s \longrightarrow F^{s-1} \longrightarrow \cdots$$

The constant-filtration functor $C \to \mathsf{Fil}(C)$ is fully faithful and exhibits C as a full subcategory of $\mathsf{Fil}(C)$.

Definition 2.4.2. Let C be a category. A **filtration on an object** $X \in C$ is a filtration $F^\star$ together with a map $F^\star \to X$ of filtrations (regarding X as a constant filtration).

More generally, let $\mathbb{Z}^{\mathrm{op}} \cup \{-\infty\}$ denote the poset obtained from $\mathbb{Z}^{\mathrm{op}}$ by adjoining an object $-\infty$ together with a unique morphism $n \to -\infty$ for every $n \in \mathbb{Z}$. Then the **category of pairs** $(F^\star \to X)$ **of filtrations on objects of** C is the functor category $\mathsf{Fun}(\mathbb{Z}^{\mathrm{op}} \cup \{-\infty\}, C)$.

The picture to keep in mind is the diagram

$$\begin{tikzcd}
\cdots \arrow[r] & F^{s+1} \arrow[r] \arrow[dr] & F^s \arrow[r] \arrow[d] & F^{s-1} \arrow[r] \arrow[dl] & \cdots \\
& & X. &
\end{tikzcd}$$

Definition 2.4.3. Let C be a category.

- A filtration $F^\star$ on X is called **exhaustive** if the canonical map $\operatorname{colim}_{s \in \mathbb{Z}^{\mathrm{op}}} F^s \to X$ is an equivalence.
- A filtration $F^\star$ is called **complete** if $F^\infty := \lim_s F^s \simeq 0$.

Definition 2.4.4. Let C be a category with a terminal object $*$ that admits cofibers, and let $F^\star \in \mathsf{Fil}(C)$ be a filtration. For $i \in \mathbb{Z}$, the **i-th associated graded piece** is

$$\mathrm{gr}^i_F = \operatorname{cofib}\left(F^{i+1} \to F^i\right).$$

The associated graded functor is denoted $\mathrm{gr}^\star \colon \mathsf{Fil}(C) \to \mathsf{Gr}(C)$.

2.4.2. *Effective motivic spectra and the slice filtration*

In motivic homotopy theory, a filtration of particular interest is the slice filtration.

Definition 2.4.5. The category of **effective motivic spectra**

$$\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S) \subseteq \mathsf{SH}(S)$$

is the smallest stable subcategory of $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ which is closed under colimits and contains $M_S(X)[i]$ for all $X \in \mathsf{Sm}_S$ and $i \in \mathbb{Z}$. More generally, for any $j \in \mathbb{Z}$, the category of **j-effective motivic spectra** is

$$\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)(j) := \mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes j} \otimes \mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S).$$

By construction, $\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)$ coincides with $\mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq \mathbb{Z}\times\{0\}}$ in the sense of Notation 2.3.14, and more generally $\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)(j)$ coincides with $\mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq \mathbb{Z}\times\{j\}}$. The subcategory $\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)$ is closed under the tensor product of $\mathsf{SH}(S)$, and hence inherits a presentably symmetric monoidal structure.

Proposition 2.4.6. *The inclusion functor $\iota^j \colon \mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)(j) \hookrightarrow \mathsf{SH}(S)$ admits a right adjoint r^j.*

Proof. By construction, $\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)(j)$ is a full subcategory of $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ closed under colimits, hence ι^j preserves colimits.

Moreover, $\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)(j)$ is presentable: it is generated under colimits by the set $\{\mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes j} \otimes M_S(X)[i] \mid X \in \mathsf{Sm}_S,\ i \in \mathbb{Z}\}$, and each such generator is compact in $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ (since X_+ is compact in $\mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S)_*$, and both $\mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{mot}} \colon \mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S)_* \to \mathsf{H}_*(S)$ and $\sigma^\infty \circ \Sigma^\infty \colon \mathsf{H}_*(S) \to \mathsf{SH}(S)$ preserve compact objects by [Lur09, Lemma 5.5.1.4]). The adjoint functor theorem [Lur09, Corollary 5.5.2.9] then gives a right adjoint r^j. □

Construction 2.4.7 (Slice filtration)**.** By Proposition 2.4.6, there is a sequence of colimit-preserving inclusions

$$\cdots \subset \mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)(j+1) \subset \mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)(j) \subset \mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)(j-1) \subset \cdots \subset \mathsf{SH}(S),$$

giving rise, for every motivic spectrum $E \in \mathsf{SH}(S)$, to a functorial filtration

$$\cdots \to \iota^{j+1} \circ r^{j+1} E \to \iota^j \circ r^j E \to \iota^{j-1} \circ r^{j-1} E \to \cdots \to E.$$

We denote this filtration by $\mathrm{Fil}^\star_{\mathrm{slice}}(E)$ and refer to it as the **slice filtration** of E. We will call $\mathrm{Fil}^0_{\mathrm{slice}}(E)$ the **effective cover** of E.

The slice filtration satisfies the following properties:

- The formation $E \mapsto \mathrm{Fil}^\star_{\mathrm{slice}}(E)$ is functorial in E and hence provides a functor $\mathsf{SH}(S) \to \mathsf{FilSH}(S)$.
- $\mathrm{Fil}^j_{\mathrm{slice}}(E) = \iota^j \circ r^j(E) \to E$ is universal for maps out of a j-effective motivic spectrum into E: any map $F \to E$ with $F \in \mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)(j)$ factors uniquely through $\mathrm{Fil}^j_{\mathrm{slice}}(E) \to E$.
- The graded piece
$$s^j(E) \;\coloneqq\; \mathrm{cofib}\big(\mathrm{Fil}^{j+1}_{\mathrm{slice}}(E) \to \mathrm{Fil}^j_{\mathrm{slice}}(E)\big),$$
called the **j-th slice** of E, satisfies $\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)(j+1) \perp s^j(E)$, i.e. $\mathrm{Map}_{\mathsf{SH}(S)}(F, s^j(E)) \simeq *$ for every $F \in \mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)(j+1)$.
- $\mathrm{Fil}^\star_{\mathrm{slice}}(E)$ is exhaustive (Definition 2.4.3): since every generator $M_S(X)$ of $\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)$ lies in $\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)(j)$ for j sufficiently small (in fact, for all $j \leq 0$), the functors $\iota^j r^j$ are eventually the identity on any fixed compact generator, so $\mathrm{colim}_{j\to-\infty} \iota^j r^j E \simeq E$.

In general, the slice filtration is not complete. The question of convergence is subtle, and addressing it will motivate the introduction of the *effective homotopy t-structure* and, in particular, of *very effective* motivic spectra, to which we now turn.

Applying the functor

$$\mathsf{SH}(S) \xrightarrow{\omega^\infty} \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp}) \xrightarrow{\Gamma} \mathsf{Sp}, \tag{2.1}$$

where Γ denotes the global sections, we equip $(\omega^\infty E)(S)$ with the filtration

$$\mathrm{Fil}^\star_{\mathrm{slice}}(\omega^\infty E)(S) := \big(\omega^\infty \mathrm{Fil}^\star_{\mathrm{slice}}(E)\big)(S),$$

which, by a slight abuse of terminology, we will also refer to as the slice filtration on $(\omega^\infty E)(S)$. Since ω^∞ is exact, the graded pieces of this filtration are $\mathrm{gr}^j_{\mathrm{slice}}(\omega^\infty E)(S) \simeq \omega^\infty s^j(E)(S) \in \mathsf{Sp}$ for $j \in \mathbb{Z}$.

***Remark* 2.4.8** (Multiplicativity). For any scheme S, the formation of the slice filtration defines a lax symmetric monoidal functor

$$\mathrm{Fil}^\star_{\mathrm{slice}} \colon \mathsf{SH}(S) \to \mathsf{FilSH}(S),$$

where the target is endowed with the Day convolution symmetric monoidal structure. Similarly, passing to graded pieces defines a symmetric monoidal functor

$$\mathrm{gr}^\star_{\mathrm{slice}} \colon \mathsf{SH}(S) \to \mathsf{GrSH}(S).$$

Furthermore, each of the functors in (2.1) is lax symmetric monoidal.

***Remark* 2.4.9** (Base change for the slice filtration). Let $f : S' \to S$ be a morphism of qcqs schemes. Since f^* preserves colimits and $f^* M_S(X) \simeq M_{S'}(X \times_S S')$ by base change, f^* sends $\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)(j)$ into $\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S')(j)$ for every $j \in \mathbb{Z}$.

Consequently, the canonical map $f^*\mathrm{Fil}^\star_{\mathrm{slice}}(E) \to f^*E$ of filtered spectra factors uniquely, by the universal property of $\mathrm{Fil}^\star_{\mathrm{slice}}(f^*E)$, through a map

$$f^*\mathrm{Fil}^\star_{\mathrm{slice}}(E) \longrightarrow \mathrm{Fil}^\star_{\mathrm{slice}}(f^*E),$$

which in turn induces on graded pieces a map of graded spectra

$$f^* s^\star E \longrightarrow s^\star f^* E.$$

If f is smooth, then f^* admits a left adjoint $f_\sharp \colon \mathsf{SH}(S') \to \mathsf{SH}(S)$, which preserves j-effective spectra (it preserves colimits, and $f_\sharp M_{S'}(X') \simeq M_S(X')$ for $X' \in \mathsf{Sm}_{S'}$, regarded as smooth over S via f). By the adjunctions $f_\sharp \dashv f^*$ and $\iota^j \dashv r^j$, this gives a natural equivalence $f^* \circ r^j \simeq r^j \circ f^*$, so f^* commutes with the formation of the slice filtration and its slices.

By continuity of $\mathsf{SH}(-)$ ([CD19, Proposition 4.3.4]), the same conclusion holds more generally when f is a pro-smooth affine morphism.

We can also construct the unstable [1] analogue of the slice filtration. For any qcqs scheme S and $j \geq 0$, set

$$\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})(j) \subset \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$$

be the subcategory generated under colimits by $\Sigma^\infty \mathbb{T}_S^{\wedge j} \wedge E$, for $E \in \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$.

Definition 2.4.10. We say an $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant Nisnevich sheaf $E \in \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$ is **unstably j-effective**, if $E \in \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})(j)$.

By same argument in Proposition 2.4.6, the inclusion $\iota^j \colon \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})(j) \hookrightarrow \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$ admits a right adjoint r^j. In the same way as for the slice filtration, this induces a functorial,

[1] "unstable" here means unstable under $\wedge \mathbb{T}_S$

exhaustive multiplicative filtration for $E \in \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$ which is now $\mathbb{N}$-indexed. We denote this filtration by

$$\cdots \to \mathrm{Fil}^{j+1}_{\text{un-slice}}(E) \to \mathrm{Fil}^{j}_{\text{un-slice}}(E) \to \mathrm{Fil}^{j-1}_{\text{un-slice}}(E) \to \cdots \to \mathrm{Fil}^{0}_{\text{un-slice}}(E) \simeq E$$

and write $s^j_u(E)$ for the j-th graded piece, which we call the **unstable slices of** E.

We now compare the unstable slice filtration to the slice filtration on $\mathsf{SH}(S)$. Observing that

$$\sigma^\infty(\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})(j)) \subset \mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)(j),$$

we obtain Beck–Chevalley style transformations $\iota^j \circ \omega^\infty \to \omega^\infty \circ \iota^j$. They induce, for each $E \in \mathsf{SH}(S)$ and $j \geq 0$, natural maps

$$\mathrm{Fil}^j_{\text{un-slice}}\omega^\infty E \to \omega^\infty \mathrm{Fil}^j_{\text{slice}}(E) \quad \text{and} \quad s^j_u \omega^\infty E \to \omega^\infty s^j E.$$

Since all these functors and transformations are compatibly lax monoidal the transformation above upgrades to a lax monoidal transformation of $\mathbb{N}$-indexed filtred and graded objects respectively:

$$\mathrm{Fil}^j_{\text{un-slice}}\omega^\infty \to \omega^\infty \mathrm{Fil}^j_{\text{slice}} \quad \text{and} \quad s^j_u \omega^\infty E \to \omega^\infty s^j.$$

Effective homotopy t-structure and very effective spectra

The category $\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)(j)$ inherits a natural t-structure from the homotopy t-structure on $\mathsf{SH}(S)$.

Definition 2.4.11 (Effective homotopy t-structure)**.** The **effective homotopy t-structure** on $\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)(j)$ is given by

$$\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)(j)_{\geq d} := \mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)(j) \cap \mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq d}, \quad \mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)(j)_{\leq d} := \mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)(j) \cap \mathsf{SH}(S)_{\leq d},$$

for $d \in \mathbb{Z}$. Unwinding the definition via Notation 2.3.14, and using that $\iota^j \colon \mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)(j) \hookrightarrow \mathsf{SH}(S)$ preserves colimits so that the intersection of connective classes is generated by the common generator at (d, j), one computes

$$\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)(j)_{\geq d} \;=\; \mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq \{(d,j)\}}.$$

The connective part of the effective homotopy t-structure on $\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)$ itself (i.e. $j = 0, d = 0$) is of independent interest.

Definition 2.4.12 (Very effective motivic spectra)**.** The category of **very effective motivic spectra**

$$\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{veff}}(S) \subseteq \mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)$$

is the smallest subcategory of $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ closed under colimits and extensions containing $M_S(X)$ for all $X \in \mathsf{Sm}_S$. More generally, for $j \in \mathbb{Z}$, set

$$\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{veff}}(S)(j) := \mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes j} \otimes \mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{veff}}(S).$$

By construction, $\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{veff}}(S) = \mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq\{(0,0)\}} = \mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)_{\geq 0}$, so very effective spectra are precisely the connective objects in $\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)$ for the effective homotopy t-structure.

***Remark* 2.4.13** (Shift of grading on twists). The tensor product with $\mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes j}$ shifts the bigrading: since $\mathbb{T}_S \simeq S^{2,1}$, we have $\mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes j} \otimes M_S(X) = \Sigma^{2j,j} M_S(X)$, which lies in bidegree (j, j) in the (simplicial, Tate) coordinates of Notation 2.3.14. Consequently, under our inherited convention for the effective homotopy t-structure on $\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)(j)$, the very effective part sits at $\geq j$ rather than ≥ 0:

$$\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{veff}}(S)(j) \;=\; \mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq\{(j,j)\}} \;=\; \mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)(j)_{\geq j}.$$

Some authors instead define the t-structure on $\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)(j)$ by transferring along $\mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes j}$, under which convention very effective objects would sit at ≥ 0. We do not adopt this convention, as the ambient homotopy t-structure on $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ is what we ultimately care about.

Proposition 2.4.14. *Let S be a Noetherian scheme of dimension $\leq d$.*

(i) Given $E \in \mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{veff}}(S)$, then $\omega^\infty(E)$ is $(-d)$-connective (Definition 2.3.20); more generally, $\omega^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}(E)^j = E(j)$ is $(j-d)$-connective for any $j \geq 0$.

(ii) Suppose $d = 1$, and let $E \in \mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)$. If $\omega^\infty(E)$ is connective, then $E \in \mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{veff}}(S)$.

Proof. (i) For Noetherian S with $\mathrm{Kr.dim}(S) \leq d$ we have $\mathrm{v.dim}(S) = \mathrm{Kr.dim}(S) \leq d$ (see the discussion following Definition 2.2.10), so Theorem 2.3.28 applies with this d. The claim then follows by combining it with Proposition 2.3.22, tracking connectivity through the $\sigma^\infty \dashv \omega^\infty$ adjunction on each Tate level.

(ii) The functor $\omega^\infty \colon \mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S) \longrightarrow \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$ is conservative and preserves colimits. Set $T := \sigma^\infty \circ \omega^\infty$; by the Barr–Beck–Lurie theorem [Lur17, Theorem 4.7.3.5], ω^∞ is comonadic, so the augmented simplicial object

$$T^{\circ\bullet+1}E \;\longrightarrow\; E$$

is ω^∞-split, and hence

$$\operatorname*{colim}_{m\in\mathbf{\Delta}^{\mathrm{op}}} T^{\circ m+1}E \;\xrightarrow{\sim}\; E.$$

Now assume that $\omega^\infty(E)$ is connective, and set $E_\bullet := T^{\circ\bullet+1}E$. By [Lur11, Remark 4.3.4],

$$E \;\simeq\; |E_\bullet| \;\simeq\; \operatorname*{colim}_{m\to\infty}\Bigl(\operatorname*{colim}_{\mathbf{\Delta}^{\mathrm{op}}_{\leq m}} E_\bullet|_{\mathbf{\Delta}^{\mathrm{op}}_{\leq m}}\Bigr),$$

and filtered colimits preserve connectivity, so it suffices to show that each finite colimit $\operatorname{colim}_{\mathbf{\Delta}^{\mathrm{op}}_{\leq m}} E_\bullet|_{\mathbf{\Delta}^{\mathrm{op}}_{\leq m}}$ is very effective. By *loc. cit.*, there is a cofiber sequence

$$\operatorname*{colim}_{\mathbf{\Delta}^{\mathrm{op}}_{\leq(m-1)}} E_\bullet|_{\mathbf{\Delta}^{\mathrm{op}}_{\leq(m-1)}} \;\longrightarrow\; \operatorname*{colim}_{\mathbf{\Delta}^{\mathrm{op}}_{\leq m}} E_\bullet|_{\mathbf{\Delta}^{\mathrm{op}}_{\leq m}} \;\longrightarrow\; M_m[m],$$

where $M_m[m]$ is a summand of E_m. Since $\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{veff}}(S)$ is closed under colimits and extensions, induction on m reduces the problem to showing that each $M_m[m]$ is very effective; since M_m is a summand of $E_m = T^{\circ m+1}E$, it further reduces to proving

$$T^{\circ m+1}E \;\in\; \mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq -m} \qquad \text{for every } m \geq 0. \tag{2.2}$$

Indeed, granting (2.2), we have $M_m \in \mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq -m}$, hence $M_m[m] \in \mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq 0}$; since $M_m[m]$ is also effective (as a summand of a shift of an effective spectrum), it is very effective. We prove (2.2) by induction on m. For $m = 0$: by hypothesis $\omega^\infty E \in \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\geq 0}$, so by Proposition 2.3.22 we have $TE = \sigma^\infty\omega^\infty E \in \mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq 0}$. For the inductive step, assume $T^{\circ m}E \in \mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq -(m-1)}$, i.e. $T^{\circ m}E[m-1] \in \mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{veff}}(S)$. Applying (i) with $d = 1$, we

obtain $\omega^\infty(T^{\circ m}E[m-1]) \in \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\geq -1}$, i.e. $\omega^\infty T^{\circ m}E \in \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\geq -m}$. By Proposition 2.3.22,

$$T^{\circ m+1}E = \sigma^\infty \omega^\infty T^{\circ m}E \ \in \ \mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq -m},$$

which is (2.2).

□

***Remark* 2.4.15** (Motivic recognition principle). The category $\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{veff}}(S)$ admits a concrete unstable description, analogous to the classical identification $\mathsf{Sp}_{\geq 0} \simeq \mathsf{CMon}^{\mathrm{gp}}(\mathsf{An})$ between connective spectra and grouplike $\mathbb{E}_\infty$-spaces. In the motivic setting, the role played classically by finite sets (via Σ^∞_+) is taken over by *framed correspondences* $\mathsf{Corr}^{\mathrm{fr}}(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$, leading to an equivalence

$$\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{veff}}(S) \ \simeq \ \mathsf{Shv}^{\mathrm{fr}}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}\big(\mathsf{Corr}^{\mathrm{fr}}(\mathsf{Sm}_S)\big)^{\mathrm{gp}}$$

under suitable hypotheses on S. Stabilizing along the $\mathbb{T}_S$-direction then yields Theorem 3.2.1. We will return to this circle of ideas in due course; see [Elm+21] for details.

2.4.3. *Slice filtration for* KGL

Recall from Definition 2.3.9 that the motivic K-theory spectrum KGL is constructed as the β-periodization of KH at $\beta\colon \mathbb{T}_S \xrightarrow{[\mathcal{O}(-1)]-[\mathcal{O}]} \mathrm{KH}$. We now study its slice filtration.

Fix a qcqs scheme S, and denote the effective cover of KGL_S by

$$\mathrm{kgl}_S \coloneqq \mathrm{Fil}^0_{\mathrm{slice}}\mathrm{KGL}_S \ \in \ \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{SH}(S)).$$

For any $E \in \mathsf{SH}(S)$, the slice filtration satisfies the functorial identifications

$$\mathrm{Fil}^j_{\mathrm{slice}}(\mathbb{T}_S \otimes E) \ \simeq \ \mathbb{T}_S \otimes \mathrm{Fil}^{j-1}_{\mathrm{slice}}(E), \qquad s^j(\mathbb{T}_S \otimes E) \ \simeq \ \mathbb{T}_S \otimes s^{j-1}(E).$$

Applied to $E = \mathrm{KGL}_S$ and combined with Bott periodicity $\beta\colon \mathbb{T}_S \otimes \mathrm{KGL}_S \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathrm{KGL}_S$, this yields

$$\mathbb{T}_S \otimes \mathrm{Fil}^{j-1}_{\mathrm{slice}}\mathrm{KGL}_S \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathrm{Fil}^j_{\mathrm{slice}}\mathrm{KGL}_S, \qquad \mathbb{T}_S \otimes s^{j-1}(\mathrm{KGL}_S) \xrightarrow{\sim} s^j(\mathrm{KGL}_S).$$

This observation leads to an alternative description of the slice filtration on KGL_S. The Bott element $\beta\colon \mathbb{T}_S \to \mathrm{kgl}_S$ together with the ring structure on kgl_S defines

$$\beta\colon \mathbb{T}_S \otimes \mathrm{kgl}_S \xrightarrow{\beta\otimes\mathrm{can}} \mathrm{kgl}_S \otimes \mathrm{kgl}_S \xrightarrow{\mathrm{mult}} \mathrm{kgl}_S,$$

and by construction the following diagram commutes:

$$\begin{tikzcd}
\mathbb{T}_S \otimes \mathrm{kgl}_S \arrow[rr, "\sim"] \arrow[dr, "\beta"'] & & \mathrm{Fil}^1_{\mathrm{slice}}\mathrm{KGL}_S \arrow[dl, "\mathrm{can}"] \\
& \mathrm{kgl}_S. &
\end{tikzcd}$$

More generally, for each $j \geq 0$ there is a compatible commutative diagram in which $\mathbb{T}_S$ is replaced by $\mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes j}$ and β by its j-fold iterate $\beta^j\colon \mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes j} \otimes \mathrm{kgl}_S \to \mathrm{kgl}_S$. We thus obtain an equivalence between the slice filtration on KGL_S

$$\mathrm{Fil}^\star_{\mathrm{slice}}\mathrm{KGL}_S = \ \cdots \longrightarrow \mathrm{Fil}^{j+1}_{\mathrm{slice}}\mathrm{KGL}_S \longrightarrow \mathrm{Fil}^j_{\mathrm{slice}}\mathrm{KGL}_S \longrightarrow \mathrm{Fil}^{j-1}_{\mathrm{slice}}\mathrm{KGL}_S \longrightarrow \cdots$$

and the **Bott filtration**

$$\mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes\star} \otimes \mathrm{kgl}_S = \cdots \longrightarrow \mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes j+1} \otimes \mathrm{kgl}_S \longrightarrow \mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes j} \otimes \mathrm{kgl}_S \longrightarrow \mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes j-1} \otimes \mathrm{kgl}_S \longrightarrow \cdots .$$

Passing to associated gradeds yields a description of the slices of KGL_S as Tate twists of the 0-th slice:

$$s^j\mathrm{KGL}_S \simeq \mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes j} \otimes s^0\mathrm{KGL}_S \quad \text{for } j \geq 0.$$

From this we deduce convergence of the slice filtration in low dimensions.

Lemma 2.4.16. *Let S be a regular Noetherian scheme of Krull dimension ≤ 1. Then $\mathrm{kgl}_S \in \mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{veff}}(S)$, and $\omega^\infty \mathrm{Fil}^j_{\mathrm{slice}}\mathrm{KGL}_S$ is $(j - \mathrm{Kr.dim}(S))$-connective as a Nisnevich sheaf of spectra.*

Proof. For the first claim, by Proposition 2.4.14((ii)) it suffices to show that $\omega^\infty\mathrm{kgl}_S$ is connective. By construction $\omega^\infty\mathrm{kgl}_S \simeq \mathrm{KH}|_{\mathsf{Sm}_S}$; since smooth schemes over a regular Noetherian base remain regular, $\mathrm{KH}(X) \simeq \mathrm{K}(X)$ on Sm_S, which is connective by Proposition 1.3.9.

For the second claim, we have $\mathrm{Fil}^j_{\mathrm{slice}}\mathrm{KGL}_S \simeq \mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes j} \otimes \mathrm{kgl}_S$ by the identification established above. Since $\mathrm{kgl}_S \in \mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{veff}}(S)$, Proposition 2.4.14((i)) applied to the graded component of index j gives that $\omega^\infty(\mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes j} \otimes \mathrm{kgl}_S)$ is $(j - \mathrm{Kr.dim}(S))$-connective. □

2.4.4. *Orientation*

Another important aspect of motivic homotopy theory is the theory of orientations.

Definition 2.4.17. Let $E \in \mathsf{SH}(S)$ be a motivic commutative ring spectrum. An **orientation** on E is a class $c_E \colon \widetilde{M}_S(\Omega^\infty\mathcal{P}ic) \to E \otimes \mathbb{T}_S$ which fits into a commutative (up to unspecified homotopy) diagram

$$\begin{tikzcd} \widetilde{M}_S(\Omega^\infty\mathcal{P}ic) \arrow[r, "c_E"] & E \otimes \mathbb{T}_S \\ \mathbb{T}_S \arrow[u, "|\mathcal{O}(1)|"] \arrow[ur, "\eta_E \otimes \mathbb{T}_S"'] & \end{tikzcd}$$

where $\widetilde{M}_S \colon \mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S)_* \to \mathsf{SH}$ is the composition $\mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S)_* \to \mathsf{H}_*(S) \to \mathsf{SH}(S)$ [2] and $\eta_E \colon \mathbf{1}_S \to E$ is the unit of E and the vertical arrow is the map corresponding to $\mathcal{O}(1)$.

There is an equivalence

$$\operatorname{colim}_m \widetilde{M}_S(\mathbb{P}^m_S) \xrightarrow{\sim} \widetilde{M}_S(\Omega^\infty\mathcal{P}ic)$$

(where the transition maps $\mathbb{P}^m_S \to \mathbb{P}^{m+1}_S$ are the closed inclusions given by the last $(m+1)$-coordinates, and each map $\mathbb{P}^m_S \to \mathcal{P}ic$ of pointed presheaves of animae on Sm_S corresponds to $\mathcal{O}(1) \in \mathrm{Pic}(\mathbb{P}^m_S)$), and it is straightforward to check that each $\widetilde{M}_S(\mathbb{P}^m_S)$ is 1-effective.

Therefore, given $E \in \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{SH}(S))$, applying $\mathrm{Fil}^1_{\mathrm{slice}}$ to any orientation $c_E \colon \widetilde{M}_S(\Omega^\infty\mathcal{P}ic) \to E \otimes \mathbb{T}_S$ yields a refined map

$$\widetilde{M}_S(\Omega^\infty\mathcal{P}ic) \longrightarrow \mathrm{Fil}^1_{\mathrm{slice}}(E \otimes \mathbb{T}_S),$$

using that $\widetilde{M}_S(\Omega^\infty\mathcal{P}ic) \simeq \operatorname{colim}_m \widetilde{M}_S(\mathbb{P}^m_S)$ is 1-effective and the universal property of $\mathrm{Fil}^1_{\mathrm{slice}}$ (see Construction 2.4.7). Post-composing with $\mathrm{Fil}^1_{\mathrm{slice}}(E \otimes \mathbb{T}_S) \to E \otimes \mathbb{T}_S$ recovers c_E; in this

[2] It can also be regarded as the left Kan extension of M_S

sense an orientation of E is equivalent data to its *first Chern class*, i.e. a compatible lift of the tautological map $\mathbb{T}_S \to \widetilde{M}_S(\Omega^\infty \mathcal{P}ic)$ through the 1-effective cover of $E \otimes \mathbb{T}_S$.

The universal example is the motivic Thom spectrum MGL, taken up in §2.6: every orientation of E factors uniquely through a morphism $\mathrm{MGL} \to E$ of commutative ring spectra. Other familiar examples include KGL (a multiplicative orientation, via the first Chern class of the tautological line bundle on $\mathbb{P}^\infty$) and the motivic Eilenberg–MacLane spectrum $\mathrm{H}\mathbb{Z}$ (the additive orientation); a systematic study of formal group laws attached to oriented motivic ring spectra will be recorded alongside the construction of MGL.

2.5. Low weights

This section is the script of my talk in the Oberseminar.

2.6. The motivic Thom spectra MGL

Chapter 3.

Framed Correspondences and Motivic Recognition Principle

The recognition principle in ordinary homotopy theory and motivic version.

3.1. Framed correspondences

3.2. Motivic infinite loop space machine

Theorem 3.2.1 (Motivic recognition principle[Elm+21],[Hoy21]). *The functor*

$$\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S) \longrightarrow \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Corr}^{\mathrm{fr}}(\mathsf{Sm}_S), \mathsf{Sp})$$

is an equivalence between symmetric monoidal categories.

Sketch of the proof.

Appendix A.

Norms on Motivic (Pre)spectra

This appendix collects the norm-functor construction of Bachmann–Hoyois, which was previewed in Chapter 1 (see Remark 1.0.2) and underlies the multiplicative structure on motivic homotopy theory used at several points in Chapter 2.

We close the chapter by sketching the construction of **norm functors** due to Bachmann–Hoyois [BH21]. These provide additional multiplicative structure on motivic homotopy theory and play a central role in the theory of motivic spectra developed in Chapter 2.

A.1. Motivation and statement

For a finite locally free morphism $p\colon T \to S$ in classical algebraic geometry, there is the **Weil restriction** $\mathrm{R}_p\colon \mathsf{Sm}_T \to \mathsf{Sm}_S$, right adjoint to pullback $p^*\colon \mathsf{Sm}_S \to \mathsf{Sm}_T$, characterized by

$$\mathrm{Hom}_S(Y, \mathrm{R}_p X) \;\simeq\; \mathrm{Hom}_T(Y \times_S T, X).$$

In the pointed setting, Weil restriction extends to a symmetric monoidal functor $p_\otimes\colon \mathsf{Sm}_{T,+} \to \mathsf{Sm}_{S,+}$ (with respect to the smash product). The core question of [BH21] is: can $p_\otimes$ be extended to motivic homotopy theory?

Theorem A.1.1 (Bachmann–Hoyois [BH21, Theorems 3.3, 4.1]). *Let $p\colon T \to S$ be a finite locally free, universally open morphism. Then there exists a symmetric monoidal functor*

$$p_\otimes\colon \mathsf{H}_*(T) \longrightarrow \mathsf{H}_*(S)$$

satisfying:

(i) $p_\otimes$ preserves sifted colimits;

(ii) $p_\otimes(X_+) \simeq (\mathrm{R}_p X)_+$ for $X \in \mathsf{Sm}_T$;

(iii) if $T = S^{\sqcup n}$ and p is the fold map, then $p_\otimes$ is the n-fold smash product;

(iv) if p is moreover finite étale, $p_\otimes$ extends to a symmetric monoidal functor $p_\otimes\colon \mathsf{SH}(T) \to \mathsf{SH}(S)$.

***Remark* A.1.2** (Universal property of $\mathcal{P}_\Sigma$). The proof of Theorem A.1.1 factors the construction through the universal sequence

$$\mathsf{Sm}_{T,+} \xrightarrow{(1)} \mathcal{P}_\Sigma(\mathsf{Sm}_T)_* \xrightarrow{(2)} \mathsf{H}_*(T) \xrightarrow{(3)} \mathsf{SH}(T).$$

Each step is a universal construction in $\mathrm{CAlg}(\mathsf{Cat}^{\mathrm{sift}})$ (presentably symmetric monoidal categories with sifted colimits). Consequently, the symmetric monoidal $p_\otimes\colon \mathsf{Sm}_{T,+} \to \mathsf{Sm}_{S,+}$ from Weil restriction has at most one sifted-colimit-preserving symmetric monoidal extension at each stage:

(i) the extension to $\mathcal{P}_\Sigma$ is unconditional;

(ii) the extension to H_* holds iff $p_\otimes$ preserves Nisnevich and $\mathbb{A}^1$ equivalences (which is the case for finite locally free universally open p);

(iii) the extension to SH holds iff $p_\otimes(\mathbb{P}^1_{T,+})$ is $\otimes$-invertible in $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ (which is the case for finite étale p).

This is a paradigmatic example of how the universal-property approach to motivic homotopy theory pays off: a hard "can we extend?" question reduces to checking elementary preservation properties.

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